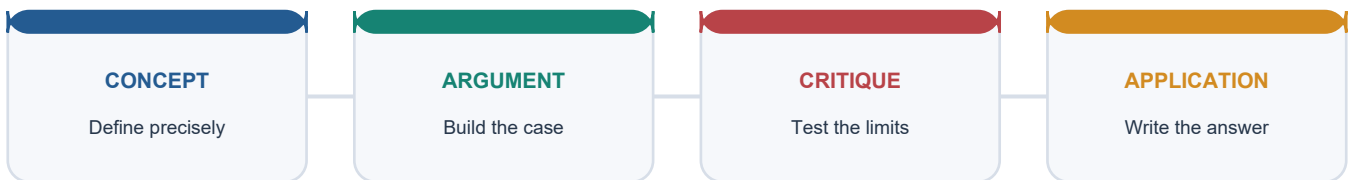


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 01 - Notions of God - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | 32 diagnostic MCQs | 13 solved previous-year parts | 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 01 - Notions of God - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Notions of God learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Notions of God : Attributes; Relation to Man and the World. (Indian and Western)*. - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion, item 1. □ Existence arguments belong to Proofs for the Existence of God, the full challenge from suffering to Problem of Evil, and semantic theory to Nature of Religious Language; they appear here only where this clause's own conceptual grounding requires them. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II, and Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so no objective question here is a previous-year question. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *contextual one-deity supremacy (henotheism)*, *one-god-at-a-time supremacy (kathenotheism)*, *exclusive one-God worship (monolatry)*, *creation from nothing (creatio ex nihilo)*, *non-composition (divine simplicity)*, *existing from itself (aseity)*, *changelessness (immutability)*, *not being acted upon (impassibility)*, *knowledge of counterfactuals of freedom (middle knowledge, scientia media)*, *God or Nature (Deus sive Natura)*, *quality-transcending Brahman (nirguṇa Brahman)*, *personal Lord (saguṇa Īśvara)*, *apparent transformation (vivarta)*, *real transformation (pariṇāma)*, *inseparability (apṛthaksiddhi)*, *body-and-self relation (śarīra-śarīrī)*, *inner controller (antaryāmin)*, *efficient and ordering cause (nimitta-kāraṇa)*, *unseen moral potency (adr̥ṣṭa)*, *essential nature-defining mark (svarūpa-lakṣaṇa)*, *accidental or relational mark (taṭastha-lakṣaṇa)*. Provenance is examinable: Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I qq.3-13 and q.25 a.3; Spinoza, *Ethics*; Molina, *Concordia*; Plantinga, *Does God Have a Nature?*; Śaṅkara, *Brahma-Sūtra-Bhāṣya*; Rāmānuja, *Śrī-Bhāṣya* and *Vedārthasaṅgraha*; R̥gveda 1.164.46 and 10.129; Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6 and 3.9; Chāndogya 6.8.7; Taittirīya 2.9; Bhagavad Gītā 18.61 and 18.63. No page, edition or invented quotation is attached to any of them.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2024	13
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the confections, inversions, misattributions and ownership errors that cost marks on this clause every year.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the demanded model from the stem first:** three parts are Western-model parts, five are Indian-school parts, two are personal/impersonal parts, two are attribute-coherence parts, and one is a manifestation part.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 to 220 words, 15 marks about 250 to 330, 20 marks about 330 to 400**.
5. Check every answer against the traps: pantheism read as panentheism, quality-transcending Brahman read as non-existence, inseparability read as identity, a nature question answered with existence proofs, transcendence

read as distance, timelessness offered as a complete solution, one-God belief equated with classical theism, and the four senses of divine manifestation merged into one.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Notions of God: Attributes; Relation to Man and the World. (Indian and Western)* - covering the conceptual grammar of a God-concept, affirmative and negative God-talk, the classification grid from monotheism to panentheism, the six role-profiles, creation from nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*) and primary/secondary causation, the full attribute package with its coherence costs, the two paradoxes and their four named exits, timeless and everlasting eternity, changelessness (immutability) and non-passibility (impassibility), non-composition (divine simplicity) with its Indian parallel, personhood without embodiment, Spinoza's substance metaphysics, non-dualism (Advaita), qualified non-dualism (Viśiṣṭādvaita), Nyāya's God (*Īśvara*), the non-creator Indian profiles, and the Hindu plurality verdict. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause: collapsing pantheism into panentheism, reading quality-transcending Brahman (*nirguṇa Brahman*) as non-existence, converting inseparability (*apṛthaksiddhi*) into identity, answering a nature-of-God question with existence proofs, spatialising transcendence, stopping at "God is outside time", equating one-God belief with classical theism, and merging four distinct senses of divine physical manifestation.

MCQ 1. What a notion of God must fix before any proof becomes relevant

This clause treats a notion of God as a structured concept, not a sacred name. Which statement states most precisely what such a notion must fix?

- A. The referent, the admissible divine predicates, the model of ultimacy, and the relations to world and to persons.
- B. The historical religion in which the word "God" first acquired a settled devotional and liturgical use.
- C. The psychological needs that devotion to a supreme being is normally expected to satisfy in believers.
- D. The empirical procedure by which the existence of a supreme being could be publicly tested or falsified.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: reference, predicates, model and relation are the four layers that make worship and explanation intelligible, and together they fix what any later proof would have to establish.
- **B:** Incorrect: chronological priority settles usage, not content; the same word carries different grammars in classical theism, in Spinoza and in non-dualism (Advaita).
- **C:** Incorrect: religious function follows from the concept rather than defining it, and a purely functional account cannot separate pantheism from panentheism.
- **D:** Incorrect: testability belongs to Topic 02, Proofs; conceptual analysis comes first, since a demonstrated first cause is not thereby personal, omniscient or worship-worthy.

Examiner trap 1: Opening with "God means the supreme being" and moving straight to arguments forfeits the classification marks; the examiner is buying the grammar of the concept, not a dictionary gloss.

MCQ 2. Affirmative and negative God-talk

Assertion (A): Negative theology (apophatic discourse) need not empty talk about God of all content.

Reason (R): Denying that creaturely predicates apply in the creaturely mode still leaves directional content - that the divine is not finite, not composite and not dependent.

- A. A is true, but R is false.
- B. A is false, but R is true.
- C. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A.
- D. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: R is not false; it states the standard defence of negation, namely that the limits removed are creaturely limits and not reality itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: A is true, because affirmative (cataphatic) speech survives negation in a purified, analogical form rather than being cancelled by it.
- **C:** Correct: the reason supplies exactly the content that keeps negation from collapsing into silence, so it explains the assertion rather than merely accompanying it.
- **D:** Incorrect: the connection is explanatory, not incidental - the residual directional content is the whole ground on which A is defended.

Examiner trap 2: Presenting negation and affirmation as rival theories loses the point: too little reserve produces anthropomorphism and too much makes reference and worship indeterminate, so the answer must state the control, not choose a side.

MCQ 3. The classification grid, stated precisely

Which pairing of a label with its defining claim is correct?

- A. Contextual one-deity supremacy (*henotheism*): the deity currently invoked is addressed with the language of supremacy without the other deities being denied.
- B. Exclusive one-God worship (*monolatry*): only one deity is held to exist, and every rival deity is declared unreal by that very worship.
- C. Classical theism: one God is affirmed, with no further commitment regarding creation, non-composition, changelessness or perfect goodness.
- D. Metaphysical oneness (*monism*): one personal creator is affirmed, so oneness of reality and oneness of deity become interchangeable claims.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the pattern F. Max Müller named in the R̥gveda, with the finer variant "one-god-at-a-time" (*kathenotheism*) for successive supremacy across hymns.
- **B:** Incorrect: exclusive worship of one God is compatible with allowing that others may exist; it is a claim about worship, not about ontology.
- **C:** Incorrect: one-God belief is only the counting claim; classical theism adds necessity, creation and sustaining, perfect goodness, eternity, changelessness and non-composition.
- **D:** Incorrect: oneness of reality denies plurality of *reality*, while one-God belief denies plurality of *deity*; the two can come apart, as quality-transcending Brahman shows.

Examiner trap 3: Using "polytheism", "henotheism" and "oneness of reality" as stylistic variants destroys the 2018 answer, because the whole question turns on which plurality - of ultimates, or of names and forms - is being asserted.

MCQ 4. The defining commitment of deism

Which statement gives the defining commitment of deism as classified in this owner?

- A. Deism denies that the world has any cause beyond itself and therefore rejects the notion of creation altogether.
- B. Deism accepts continuing miracles and special revelation while denying that the creator is personal in any sense.
- C. Deism identifies God with the totality of nature and therefore abandons the creator-and-creature distinction.
- D. Deism affirms a creator of the world and its natural order while rejecting continuing revelatory or miraculous intervention.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is a denial of creation, not deism; the deist keeps the creator and removes only the continuing intervention.
- **B:** Incorrect: this inverts the position, since it is precisely miracles and special revelation that deism withdraws while retaining a personal source.
- **C:** Incorrect: identity of God and nature is pantheism; deism preserves the distinction and lets the world run by its own established laws.
- **D:** Correct: creation plus rational order plus withdrawal is the "cosmic clockmaker" profile, religiously remote yet metaphysically theistic.

Examiner trap 4: Writing that deism "is really atheism" is a straight error: deism affirms a creator, and the correct criticism is religious remoteness, not disbelief.

MCQ 5. Identity, inclusion and Spinoza's exact position

Consider the following statements.

1. Pantheism asserts identity between God and all-inclusive reality.
2. Panentheism asserts that the world exists in God while God exceeds the world.
3. Spinoza's God is the aggregate of physical bodies making up the material universe.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 fails, because finite things are modes of one infinite substance expressed under infinitely many attributes, of which we know Thought and Extension.
- **B:** Incorrect: it repeats the same reduction of Spinoza's substance to matter while dropping the correct identity claim in statement 1.
- **C:** Correct: identity for pantheism and inclusion-with-excess for panentheism are the two defining formulas, and both are stated accurately here.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 2 are sound, but including statement 3 converts Spinoza's substance monism into a materialist inventory of bodies.

Examiner trap 5: "Pantheism means God is the universe" is examiner shorthand that becomes wrong the moment Spinoza is named, because intelligible reality under Thought is as much God as extended reality is.

MCQ 6. Role-profiles are not synonyms

Which statement about the role-profiles of "God" is correct?

- A. Creator and sustainer state one role twice, since making a thing already includes keeping it in being over time.
- B. Moral governor is a devotional image only, and it generates no distinct philosophical pressure of its own.
- C. Ground of being is a revisionary profile: it makes God the non-dependent source of actuality rather than one being among beings, and it makes personality and worship harder to state.
- D. Absolute and creator are equivalent profiles, because whatever creates must stand in a real relation to what it creates.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: creation concerns the dependence of creaturely being as such, while sustaining concerns its continuation at every moment, and the second raises the timelessness problem the first does not.
- **B:** Incorrect: moral governance carries its own pressure - autonomy, desert and the distribution of suffering - which is why it is listed as a separate role.
- **C:** Correct: Paul Tillich's "being-itself" is a revisionary profile rather than a proof or a synonym for every classical use of the word "God", and its cost is exactly the difficulty about addressability.
- **D:** Incorrect: absoluteness asserts non-relativity and ontological basicness, and an impersonal absolute may cease to resemble a personal creator at all.

Examiner trap 6: Treating creator, sustainer, ruler, moral governor, ground and absolute as one list of honorifics wastes the relation question in 2024, where the marks lie in which role is doing the causal work.

MCQ 7. Creation from nothing, stated without the picture-thinking

Which statement expresses creation from nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*) correctly?

- A. God fashioned the world out of a primordial stuff called "nothing", which existed before the creative act began.
- B. Creation denies any independent material co-principle and asserts that the whole being of creatures depends continuously on God.
- C. Creation is the first event in a temporal series, after which the world persists by its own inertia without further dependence.
- D. Creation is the rearrangement of eternal atoms by an intelligent orderer who supplies motion but not existence.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: "nothing" is not a material; the phrase denies a material co-principle rather than naming an exotic one.
- **B:** Correct: the doctrine is one of total ontological dependence, which is why God can be the primary sustaining cause through which genuine secondary natural causes still operate.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is closer to the deist picture; classical theism makes dependence continuous rather than initial.
- **D:** Incorrect: that is the Nyāya profile, in which eternal atoms remain the material cause and God is the efficient, ordering cause - a deliberate contrast, not a definition.

Examiner trap 7: Answering the 2024 manifestation question with a manufacturing image concedes the objection before it is stated; the answer must first separate making from ontological dependence.

MCQ 8. Power over the absolutely possible

An objector argues that an omnipotent God must be able to create a stone too heavy to lift, and that either ability or inability refutes omnipotence. Which reply is philosophically standard for this owner?

- A. The objection succeeds, so omnipotence must be abandoned and replaced by the claim that God is merely the most powerful existing being.
- B. The objection fails because God's power is exercised only over spiritual realities, so questions about stones are category mistakes.
- C. The objection fails because divine power extends only to what God has actually decided to do, and nothing else is a genuine task.
- D. The objection fails because a contradictory description names no possible object of power, and the paradox is best restated as a tension between first-order and second-order power.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: comparative superiority is a weaker claim than the tradition asserts, and the restriction to the absolutely possible already blocks the objection without that retreat.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in classical theism confines divine power to spiritual objects; the restriction is modal, not regional.
- **C:** Incorrect: reducing power to actual decisions confuses power with its exercise and would make omnipotence unfalsifiable rather than coherent.
- **D:** Correct: Aquinas restricts omnipotence to the absolutely possible (*Summa Theologiae* I q.25 a.3), and J. L. Mackie's framing distinguishes power over things from power to determine what powers exist.

Examiner trap 8: Replying only "God cannot do the logically impossible" without naming the first-order/second-order distinction leaves the sharper version of the paradox untouched and caps the answer.

MCQ 9. The deliberate outlier on the eternal truths

Which position holds that even the necessary truths depend on the divine will, thereby accepting that logic itself is contingent?

- A. Aquinas's restriction of omnipotence to the absolutely possible.
- B. Descartes's doctrine that God freely creates the eternal truths.
- C. Molina's account of knowledge of counterfactuals of freedom.
- D. Ockham's distinction between hard facts and soft facts.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Aquinas moves in the opposite direction, treating contradictions as non-things so that they place no limit on power.
- **B:** Correct: universal possibilism is coherent but expensive, because it purchases unrestricted power at the price of making the eternal truths contingent on will.
- **C:** Incorrect: middle knowledge (*scientia media*) addresses foreknowledge of free acts, not the modal status of necessary truths.
- **D:** Incorrect: the hard/soft distinction concerns the fixity of the past, not the dependence of logic on the divine will.

Examiner trap 9: Using Descartes as the default theistic reply misrepresents the tradition; he is the outlier, and citing him as standard doctrine costs precision marks.

MCQ 10. The foreknowledge dilemma, premise by premise

Which statement reproduces the foreknowledge dilemma in the form the examiner rewards?

- A. Divine knowledge causes the foreseen act, so the agent is compelled and freedom is destroyed.
- B. God learns what agents will do only after they act, so exhaustive foreknowledge is impossible.
- C. Free acts have no reasons at all if they are known in advance, so rational agency collapses.
- D. God infallibly believed at an earlier time that the agent will act; the past is now fixed; an infallible belief cannot be false; so the agent cannot do otherwise.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the dilemma is modal rather than causal, and every serious version concedes that knowing is not causing.
- **B:** Incorrect: this denies the omniscience the question presupposes instead of exposing the tension inside it.
- **C:** Incorrect: a known act can remain fully reason-responsive; foreknowledge threatens alternative possibilities, not rationality.
- **D:** Correct: infallible past belief plus accidental necessity of the past yields the fixity of the future act, which is exactly where the argument must be attacked.

Examiner trap 10: Writing that "God's knowledge does not cause the act, hence there is no problem" answers a premise nobody defends and leaves the fixity premise untouched.

MCQ 11. The four named exits and their costs

Match each reply to the foreknowledge dilemma with the cost usually charged against it.

- A. Timeless eternity denies that there is any *foreknowledge*; hard/soft facts must be specified non-circularly; middle knowledge faces the grounding objection; open theism revises the classical attribute.
- B. Timeless eternity faces the grounding objection; hard/soft facts revise the attribute; middle knowledge denies foreknowledge; open theism must be specified non-circularly.
- C. Timeless eternity revises the classical attribute; hard/soft facts deny foreknowledge; middle knowledge must be specified non-circularly; open theism faces the grounding objection.
- D. Timeless eternity must be specified non-circularly; hard/soft facts face the grounding objection; middle knowledge revises the attribute; open theism denies foreknowledge.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the Boethian move removes temporal priority, the Ockhamist move relocates fixity, Molinism buys knowledge of counterfactuals of freedom at the price of truthmakers, and open theism amends omniscience itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: it transfers the grounding objection from middle knowledge, where it originates, to the eternity reply, which faces a different problem about divine responsiveness.
- **C:** Incorrect: eternity does not revise omniscience - that is open theism's move - and the soft-fact strategy does not deny foreknowledge at all.
- **D:** Incorrect: the non-circularity demand belongs to the hard/soft distinction, and open theism denies future truths rather than foreknowledge as such.

Examiner trap 11: Naming all four exits without stating which premise each one denies produces a list rather than an argument; the verdict must say what the reconciliation costs.

MCQ 12. Timeless possession of life, and its dilemma

Which statement about divine eternity is correct?

- A. Eternity means unending duration through time, and no philosopher in this tradition has proposed any alternative reading.
- B. Eternity may be read either as timeless possession of life or as everlasting existence through all time, and the timeless reading raises a dilemma about contingency.
- C. Eternity entails that God cannot be the cause of temporal effects, since a timeless cause could only produce timeless results.
- D. Eternity is a devotional honorific with no bearing on the coherence of knowledge, action or responsiveness.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the everlasting reading exists, but the timeless reading is the classical one, and the contrast between them is itself examinable.
- **B:** Correct: one timeless act can ground temporal effects, yet if no alternative divine act is possible, the contingency of creation is placed under pressure.
- **C:** Incorrect: the standard position is precisely that a single timeless act grounds a temporal order; the difficulty concerns responsiveness, not causal reach.
- **D:** Incorrect: eternity constrains what can be said about action, knowledge of tensed facts and response, so it is doctrinally loaded rather than decorative.

Examiner trap 12: Asserting that God is "beyond time" and stopping there converts a live dilemma into a slogan; state the temporal effects and the contingency cost in the same sentence.

MCQ 13. Changelessness against religious personality

Which reading of changelessness (immutability) and non-passibility (impassibility) is defensible on this owner's account?

- A. Constancy of character and purpose is affirmed, and new temporal relations or effects are distinguished from intrinsic change in God.
- B. God is entirely inert, so words like knowing, loving and responding are strictly meaningless when used of the divine.
- C. God changes with the world in every respect, so the classical attribute is simply abandoned as incoherent.
- D. Changelessness applies to God's essence but implies that God has no relation to creatures of any kind whatever.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: distinguishing intrinsic change from new relations or effects preserves both perfection and address, though the distinction itself remains contested.
- **B:** Incorrect: inertness is a caricature; classical writers assert constancy, not the absence of knowledge and love.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is the process revision, which is available as a contrast but is not the classical position being interrogated.
- **D:** Incorrect: denying every relation preserves metaphysical perfection by destroying religious personality, which is the objection rather than the reply.

Examiner trap 13: Defending changelessness by making God emotionally inert wins the metaphysics and loses the religion; the verdict should concede that the repair narrows what the believer wanted to assert.

MCQ 14. Non-composition and the two hardest objections

The doctrine of divine simplicity denies every kind of composition in God. Which statement pairs the doctrine with its two standard objections correctly?

- A. It denies composition; the objections are that God would then be spatially extended and that God could not be worshipped.
- B. It denies composition; the objections are that God would be temporal and that divine goodness would depend on an external standard.
- C. It denies composition; the objections are that creation becomes necessary and that the divine attributes would be many things rather than one.
- D. It denies composition; the objections are modal collapse, since God is identical with the divine act of will, and Plantinga's point that if God is identical with a property then God is a property and not an agent.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: extension is denied by simplicity rather than entailed by it, and unworshippability is a downstream religious complaint rather than the technical objection.
- **B:** Incorrect: temporality is denied by eternity, and the independence of goodness is the Euthyphro problem, which belongs to Religion and Morality.
- **C:** Incorrect: the first half is a garbled version of modal collapse, and the second half states the doctrine's denial rather than an objection to it.
- **D:** Correct: modal collapse threatens the contingency of creation, and Plantinga's objection in *Does God Have a Nature?* attacks the property-identity reading directly.

Examiner trap 14: Glossing simplicity as God being "uncomplicated" throws away a technical thesis about composition, essence and existence and guarantees a mid-band script.

MCQ 15. The Indian parallel to non-composition

Which statement gives the Indian analogue of the simplicity dispute accurately?

- A. Being, consciousness and bliss (*sat-cit-ānanda*) are essential nature-defining marks (*svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*) rather than qualities in a substrate, while defining Brahman as world-cause is the accidental or relational mark (*taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*).
- B. Being, consciousness and bliss are three separate substances that jointly compose Brahman, exactly as body and soul compose a human being.
- C. Rāmānuja endorses the quality-less absolute and adds only that devotion is empirically useful for ordinary worshippers.
- D. Madhva denies attributes to Viṣṇu altogether, which is why his system is classified as a form of non-dualism.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the essential-mark and relational-mark distinction is the functional Indian analogue of non-composition, and it is the discriminating detail that lifts a 15- or 20-marker.
- **B:** Incorrect: treating the three terms as components reintroduces exactly the composition the formula denies.
- **C:** Incorrect: Rāmānuja attacks the quality-less absolute head-on, arguing that a wholly undetermined entity is neither knowable, nameable nor worshippingable, so Brahman must be qualified (*saṁśeṣa*).
- **D:** Incorrect: Madhva takes the third route, using a real distinguisher (*viśeṣa*) within a partless substance so that Viṣṇu can possess genuine attributes without composition.

Examiner trap 15: Importing Aquinas's vocabulary into Vedānta without the essential-mark and relational-mark distinction produces a comparison the examiner cannot mark as informed.

MCQ 16. Personhood without embodiment

Which statement about divine personhood is correct?

- A. Personhood requires a body, since intelligence and will are known to us only in embodied agents with sensory organs.
- B. Personhood requires masculine language, because scriptural usage settles the metaphysics of the divine nature.
- C. Personhood means intelligence, will, knowledge, love and addressability, predicated analogically rather than univocally of a non-corporeal reality.
- D. Personhood is incompatible with transcendence, so any personal God must be a finite being inside the world.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: our access to personal predicates is embodied, but the inference from how we learn a word to what it must denote is exactly the anthropomorphic fallacy.
- **B:** Incorrect: masculine or feminine language establishes no biological sex in a non-corporeal God, though exclusive usage does shape authority and imagination.
- **C:** Correct: analogical predication preserves real reference and addressability while refusing univocal transfer from finite psychology.
- **D:** Incorrect: classical theism holds transcendence and personality together, and Viśiṣṭādvaita makes a supremely personal Brahman the transcendent whole.

Examiner trap 16: Answering the personal/impersonal question by treating "personal" as human-shaped destroys the 2019 and 2023 parts, because both sides of the debate reject that reading.

MCQ 17. The one-substance argument

Which sequence reconstructs Spinoza's argument for one substance correctly?

- A. Substance is conceived through itself; two substances cannot share an attribute; an absolutely infinite substance excludes any rival substance; therefore only God or Nature is substance.
- B. Every substance is caused by another; an infinite regress is impossible; therefore one substance is uncaused; therefore that substance is a personal creator.
- C. Minds and bodies are substances; substances interact causally; therefore a third substance unites them; therefore God is that unifying substance.
- D. Attributes are perceived by the intellect; perception is unreliable; therefore substance is unknowable; therefore God is beyond every attribute.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: self-conception, non-shared attributes and absolute infinity together leave no room for a second substance, which is why finite things must be modes.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a cosmological argument to a personal creator, which Spinoza's necessitarian system deliberately refuses.
- **C:** Incorrect: minds and bodies are finite modes under Thought and Extension, not substances requiring a third substance to unite them.
- **D:** Incorrect: Spinoza defines an attribute as what the intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance, so attributes disclose rather than conceal.

Examiner trap 17: Writing "Spinoza says God is nature" without the substance-attribute-mode machinery answers the 2022 part but not the 2024 part, which asks how the notion is *embedded* in the metaphysics.

MCQ 18. Divine freedom in Spinoza

Which statement about Spinoza's God is correct?

- A. God chooses among alternative possible worlds and selects the best, which is why the world exhibits order.
- B. God acts from the necessity of the divine nature, and freedom means self-determination rather than choice among alternatives.
- C. God creates at a first moment and then withdraws, leaving nature to run by laws already established.
- D. God is a transitive cause standing outside nature and acting upon it from without.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: best-world selection presupposes deliberation among alternatives, which necessitarianism excludes.
- **B:** Correct: redefining freedom as action from one's own nature is Spinoza's reply to the charge that his God loses freedom, providence and personality.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is deism, and Spinoza's God neither withdraws from nature nor chooses to create it.
- **D:** Incorrect: Spinoza's God is the immanent, not the transitive, cause of all things, which is precisely why no creator-creature gap opens.

Examiner trap 18: Calling Spinoza a deist because both reduce miracles conflates withdrawal with identity and inverts the God-world relation the question is testing.

MCQ 19. Two standpoints and apparent transformation

Which statement about non-dualism (Advaita) is correct?

- A. Quality-transcending Brahman and the personal Lord (*Īśvara*) are two equally ultimate realities standing side by side.
- B. The world is sheer non-existence, so the rope-snake illustration means that nothing whatever appears.
- C. Brahman really transforms into the world, so the relation between them is one of genuine modification (*pariṇāma*).
- D. The personal Lord is Brahman at the transactional level (*vyāvahārika*), while quality-transcending Brahman is ultimate (*pāramārthika*), the world being apparent transformation (*vivarta*).

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two are related by level, not by parity; the personal Lord is Brahman as related to the cosmic power of appearance (*māyā*).
- **B:** Incorrect: the world is empirically available and sublatale, not absolute nothing - the snake genuinely appears, which is the point of the illustration.
- **C:** Incorrect: real transformation is the Viśiṣṭādvaita and Sāṃkhya route; Advaita's world is apparent transformation, so Brahman undergoes no real change.
- **D:** Correct: the level distinction is what allows Advaita to honour devotion while denying that plurality is finally real.

Examiner trap 19: Saying "for Advaita the world is unreal" without the sublation vocabulary invites the standard objection that experience is denied, and the 2022 answer then loses its qualification.

MCQ 20. The terminology control that examiners notice

Which statement uses the technical vocabulary of Advaita correctly?

- A. Quality-transcending Brahman is ineffable because objectifying predication fails, while indeterminability (*anirvacanīya*) is the status of the cosmic power of appearance and the world-appearance.
- B. Quality-transcending Brahman is itself indeterminable (*anirvacanīya*), being neither real nor unreal in exactly the sense in which the world-appearance is neither.
- C. Both Brahman and the world-appearance are indeterminable, which is why the two are finally identical in status.
- D. Neither Brahman nor the world-appearance is indeterminable, since Advaita admits only one level of truth.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Brahman is *sat*, the one reality, and its ineffability is the failure of predication (*avācya*; "whence words turn back", Taittirīya Upaniṣad 2.9; method: *neti neti*, Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 2.3.6).
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the commonest terminological error in Vedānta scripts, since indeterminability marks what is different from both the real and the unreal, which Brahman is not.
- **C:** Incorrect: collapsing the statuses erases the level distinction on which the whole system rests.
- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita explicitly works with the transactional and ultimate levels, and sublation presupposes exactly that difference.

Examiner trap 20: Glossing quality-transcending Brahman as "indeterminable" reads as second-hand knowledge; the examiner has seen the phrase misapplied often enough to treat it as a marker.

MCQ 21. Inseparability without identity

Which statement about Rāmānuja's qualified non-dualism is correct?

- A. Selves are identical with Brahman, so liberation consists in recognising that the individual self was always the whole of Brahman.
- B. Selves and matter are real qualifications forming the body of Brahman, related by inseparability (*aprthaksiddhi*), with God as both material and efficient cause.
- C. Selves are appearances produced by the cosmic power of appearance and are cancelled when knowledge arises.
- D. Selves are eternally separate substances with no dependence on God, related to him only by moral obligation.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is the Advaita thesis; Rāmānuja preserves difference within dependence, so the self never becomes the whole of God.
- **B:** Correct: the body-and-self relation (*śarīra-śarīrī*) makes the world a real transformation (*pariṇāma*) rather than an appearance, and grounds devotion and surrender.
- **C:** Incorrect: cancellation of the self belongs to the rival system; here the individual self remains eternally real in communion.
- **D:** Incorrect: complete independence of selves would abolish the inseparability that defines the system and would move the position towards Madhva's dualism without his dependence axiom.

Examiner trap 21: Translating inseparability as identity is the single most costly error in the 2022 and 2020 parts, because it converts qualified non-dualism into the system it was built to refute.

MCQ 22. The nature of God in Nyāya

Which statement states the Nyāya notion of God (*Īśvara*) correctly?

- A. God is the material cause of the world, since atoms are produced from the divine substance at the beginning of each cycle.
- B. God is one self among many finite selves and is bound by unseen moral potency (*adr̥ṣṭa*) exactly as they are.
- C. God is a devotional postulate with no cosmological function, added to the system only in later theistic literature.
- D. God is one eternal, incorporeal, omniscient self who is the efficient and ordering cause of the world and the supervisor of karma, while eternal atoms remain the material cause.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the material cause is the eternal atoms; conflating the two destroys the causal architecture the 2021 question is testing.
- **B:** Incorrect: God is distinct from finite selves precisely in being untouched by karmic bondage while administering its fruits.
- **C:** Incorrect: God performs indispensable ordering and moral-governance work, and in the theistic profile is also the authoritative source of scripture.
- **D:** Correct: one, eternal, incorporeal, omniscient, efficient cause and karmic governor is the exact profile, with atoms retained as material cause.

Examiner trap 22: Answering the 2021 nature question by reciting Udayana's inferences imports Topic 02 and leaves the actual demand - the attributes and causal role - unanswered.

MCQ 23. Religion without a creator inside India

Which statement about the non-creator Indian profiles is correct?

- A. Classical Yoga's special self (*puruṣa-viśeṣa*) creates nature and directs its evolution from primordial matter.
- B. Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya, Buddhism and Jainism dispense with a creator God while retaining accounts of moral order, ultimacy or liberation.
- C. All Indian systems are theistic once their scriptural commitments are examined carefully enough.
- D. Non-creator systems are best described as irreligious, since religion requires an omnipotent maker of the world.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the special self is untouched by affliction and karma and functions as the archetypal teacher, not as the creator of nature's evolution.
- **B:** Correct: the eternal Veda and ritual order, independent selves and primordial nature, and the non-creator paths of Buddhism and Jainism each preserve religion without a maker.
- **C:** Incorrect: theistic reinterpretation flattens exactly the internal diversity the Indian half of this clause is asking about.
- **D:** Incorrect: "non-theistic" does not mean irreligious or morally empty; each profile retains ultimacy, discipline and liberation.

Examiner trap 23: Writing that "Indian philosophy is spiritual and therefore theistic" collapses the Indian material into one voice and forfeits the parity marks the paper reserves for precision.

MCQ 24. The verdict on Hindu plurality

Which verdict on "Is Hinduism polytheistic?" is best supported by the evidence this owner allows?

- A. It is straightforwardly polytheistic, since temples, festivals and village practice address many deities with distinct competencies.
- B. It is straightforwardly monotheistic, since one existent is spoken of variously by the wise (Ṛgveda 1.164.46).
- C. It is straightforwardly monistic, since the Upaniṣads reduce the many gods to one reality.
- D. It is not adequately described as polytheistic: plural practice, contextual supremacy, sectarian one-God devotion and Upaniṣadic oneness coexist, so plurality lies in names, forms and access rather than in ultimates.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the plural practice is real and must be conceded, but conceding it does not settle the question of plural *ultimates*.
- **B:** Incorrect: one verse cannot carry the whole verdict, and the cosmogonic hymn Ṛgveda 10.129 (*Nāsadīya*) even doubts whether the highest overseer knows.
- **C:** Incorrect: Bṛhadāraṇyaka 3.9 does reduce "three and three thousand" gods to one, but ritual and sectarian life is not thereby abolished.
- **D:** Correct: with the chosen deity (*iṣṭadevatā*), descent-forms (*avatāra*) and the sectarian one-God theisms added, the graded verdict is the only defensible one - and the imported nature of the category should be stated.

Examiner trap 24: Answering with a bare yes or no throws away the 2018 part; the criterion - plurality of ultimates against plurality of names and forms - must be announced before it is applied.

Remedial MCQs - common-error repair

These eight drills are diagnostic rather than encyclopaedic. Each targets one error that recurs in scripts on this clause; work them only after the twenty-four core questions.

MCQ 25. Repairing the pantheism and panentheism conflation

A script writes: "Panentheism is only a softer word for pantheism, since both make the world divine." What exactly is wrong?

- A. Nothing is wrong, because both positions deny that God transcends the world in any sense at all.
- B. The error is verbal only, since the two words differ in origin but not in the relation they assert.
- C. Panentheism is the stronger identity claim, because inclusion is a tighter relation than mere identity.
- D. Identity leaves no divine reality beyond the world, whereas inclusion-with-excess keeps immanence and transcendence together, and this difference decides what worship, providence and evil can mean.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: panentheism affirms that God exceeds the world, which is a transcendence claim that pantheism drops.
- **B:** Incorrect: the difference is structural, and it changes the God-world relation rather than the label attached to it.
- **C:** Incorrect: inclusion is weaker than identity in exactly the relevant respect, since it leaves a divine remainder outside the world.
- **D:** Correct: the two consequences named - the availability of transcendence and the intelligibility of address - are what the distinction is for.

Examiner trap 25: The conflation usually enters through the sentence "God is in everything"; that phrase is neutral between the two positions and must be replaced by the exact relation.

MCQ 26. Repairing "quality-transcending Brahman means nothing exists"

A script writes: "Since Brahman is without qualities, Advaita's ultimate is an empty nothing." What is the correct reply?

- A. The objection is decisive, and Advaita therefore abandons the quality-transcending description in its later literature.
- B. The objection fails because Advaita in fact ascribes ordinary empirical qualities to Brahman at the ultimate level.
- C. Negation removes limiting empirical predicates rather than reality, and Brahman is affirmed as being, consciousness and bliss (*sat-cit-ānanda*) as essential nature-defining marks.
- D. The objection fails because the world alone is real, so nothing turns on how Brahman is described.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Advaita retains the description and answers the charge; it is Rāmānuja who presses the objection, and the reply is doctrinal, not a retreat.
- **B:** Incorrect: empirical qualities belong to the transactional level, and ascribing them ultimately would concede the objection.
- **C:** Correct: apophatic removal of finite predicates leaves a positively affirmed non-dual reality, which is why the marks lie in the word "limiting".
- **D:** Incorrect: this inverts the system, in which the world is dependent and sublatale rather than the sole reality.

Examiner trap 26: Answering the objection with "Brahman is beyond words, so no reply is needed" abandons the argument; the reply must state what negation removes and what it leaves.

MCQ 27. Repairing inseparability read as identity

A script writes: "For Rāmānuja the self is inseparable from God, and therefore the self is God." Where does the inference fail?

- A. It fails because Rāmānuja denies that selves are real, so nothing can be inseparable from God.
- B. It fails because inseparability holds only during liberation and not in ordinary embodied life.
- C. It fails because inseparability is a relation between a qualifier and what it qualifies, so the self belongs to God without ever becoming the whole of God.
- D. It fails because Rāmānuja treats the self as the body of God and the world as the soul of God.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the reality of selves is precisely what qualified non-dualism defends against the appearance-based account.
- **B:** Incorrect: the dependence is permanent, and liberation is communion rather than the onset of a relation that was previously absent.
- **C:** Correct: dependence without numerical identity is the whole content of the doctrine, and it is what allows devotion and surrender to remain intelligible.
- **D:** Incorrect: the relation is stated the other way round - selves and matter form the body, and Brahman is the indwelling self.

Examiner trap 27: The inference is often smuggled in by the English word "one"; write "inseparable but not identical" explicitly, because the examiner is looking for that qualification.

MCQ 28. Repairing the ownership error in the Nyāya question

A 2021-style question asks for the nature of God in Nyāya, and the script reconstructs Udayana's inferences at length. What is the fault?

- A. There is no fault, since the nature of God in Nyāya is exhausted by the arguments that establish God.
- B. The demand is the divine profile - one, eternal, incorporeal, omniscient, efficient cause, karmic governor - while the inferences belong to Proofs for the Existence of God.
- C. The fault is stylistic, since the inferences are correct but should have been summarised more briefly.
- D. The fault is that Nyāya has no doctrine of divine attributes, so the question cannot be answered as printed.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: an argument that something exists does not by itself state what that thing is, which is exactly the distinction this clause enforces.
- **B:** Correct: the owner supplies the attribute and relation profile, and the cross-topic firewall keeps the inference apparatus with Topic 02.
- **C:** Incorrect: the problem is not length but relevance, and a shorter irrelevant passage would still miss the demand.
- **D:** Incorrect: Nyāya supplies a detailed profile, including omniscience, incorporeality, efficient causation and the administration of unseen moral potency (*adr̥ṣṭa*).

Examiner trap 28: A single sentence such as "God is proved by the argument from effects, and his nature follows" is enough to trigger this fault; state the profile first and route the proofs away explicitly.

MCQ 29. Repairing spatialised transcendence

A script writes: "God is transcendent, which means God is far away from the world, and immanent, which means God is physically inside it." What is the correction?

- A. Transcendence should be dropped, since a God beyond the world could not act within it.
- B. Immanence should be dropped, since presence inside the world would make God a part of the world.
- C. Transcendence signifies ontological independence rather than spatial remoteness, and immanence signifies sustaining presence and activity rather than physical inclusion.
- D. Both terms are devotional images with no philosophical content, so the sentence is harmless.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the classical position holds both together, and dropping transcendence would concede the world's independence.
- **B:** Incorrect: immanence correctly understood does not make God a worldly part; it makes God the sustaining ground of worldly being.
- **C:** Correct: replacing the spatial picture with dependence language is what makes the 2023 part answerable, since the question asks in what *sense* both hold.
- **D:** Incorrect: both terms carry precise metaphysical commitments, and the loose reading generates the pantheism confusion in the next paragraph.

Examiner trap 29: Diagrams with God drawn "above" and "inside" the world reinforce the error; if a diagram is used, label the arrows with dependence and sustaining rather than with distance.

MCQ 30. Repairing the "God is outside time" shortcut

A script answers the freedom-and-foreknowledge question by asserting that God is timeless, and stops there. What is missing?

- A. Nothing is missing, since timelessness removes the problem entirely and no further statement is required.
- B. The script must say which premise the eternity move targets - the fixity of the past - and must then pay the cost about divine responsiveness and contingency.
- C. The script must abandon timelessness, because no classical writer defends it as a reply to this dilemma.
- D. The script must add that divine knowledge causes the act, since that is what timelessness implies.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the entailment from infallible knowledge to the act remains even without temporal priority, so the assertion alone settles nothing.
- **B:** Correct: naming the premise denied, and then conceding the responsiveness cost, is what converts an assertion into an argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Boethian and Thomist tradition defends precisely this move; the fault is incompleteness, not error.
- **D:** Incorrect: making knowledge causal concedes the crude version of the objection that every serious party rejects.

Examiner trap 30: The shortcut is attractive because it sounds decisive; examiners treat it as the standard mid-band answer, and the marks sit in the sentence that follows it.

MCQ 31. Repairing "one God, therefore classical theism"

A script treats belief in one God as equivalent to classical theism. What does the equation omit?

- A. It omits necessity, creation and continuous sustaining, perfect goodness, eternity, changelessness and non-composition, which one-God belief by itself does not supply.
- B. It omits nothing of substance, since any monotheist is committed to the classical attribute package by implication.
- C. It omits only the historical claim that classical theism developed within a particular philosophical tradition.
- D. It omits the requirement that God be worshipped exclusively, which is the sole difference between the two.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the counting claim fixes the number of deities and leaves every metaphysical commitment of classical theism still to be argued.
- **B:** Incorrect: a deist and a finite-God theorist can both be monotheists while rejecting central classical claims.
- **C:** Incorrect: the difference is doctrinal rather than historical, and the historical remark would not repair the substantive omission.
- **D:** Incorrect: exclusive worship is the mark of one-God worship (*monolatry*) and does not by itself deliver necessity, simplicity or eternity.

Examiner trap 31: The equation usually appears in the opening line as "theism, that is, belief in one God"; correct it in the definition itself, because everything downstream inherits the imprecision.

MCQ 32. Repairing the four senses of divine physical manifestation

The 2024 statement claims that the ultimate cause of the world must have some physical manifestation. Which analysis best separates the notions at stake?

- A. Incarnation and material causation are the same claim, so the statement is true in every tradition that accepts descent-forms.
- B. Physical manifestation is required by Viśiṣṭādvaita, since calling the world God's body means God has a physical form.
- C. Descent or manifestation, embodiment, material causation and metaphysical dependence are four distinct notions, and ultimacy requires only the last, which physical form would in fact compromise.
- D. Pantheism refutes the statement outright, because identifying God with nature removes every question about manifestation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a descent-form is a mode of appearing, while material causation concerns what the world is made from; they answer different questions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the body-and-self relation makes the world God's real dependent body without giving God an anthropomorphic physical form.
- **C:** Correct: distinguishing the four notions lets the answer concede the religious weight of manifestation while denying the metaphysical necessity claimed by the statement.
- **D:** Incorrect: identification with nature is one contested position among several and cannot by itself refute a general modal claim about ultimacy.

Examiner trap 32: Agreeing with the statement because "we know causes only through their effects" imports an epistemic point into a metaphysical claim; the answer must mark that shift explicitly.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

All 13 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks

The models are pedagogic examiner-grade answers, not official UPSC solutions. No primary Notions-of-God question appears in the audited 2025 paper.

Corpus note: The audited Paper II corpus contains **13 topic-owned PYQs** from 2018-2024. There was **no primary topic-owned "Notions of God" PYQ in 2025**.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"Is Hinduism poly-theistic? Give reasons for your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Take a reasoned position, not a yes/no vote
Core issue	Whether plurality of Hindu deities entails metaphysical polytheism
Scope boundary	Classify Hindu traditions; do not attempt a history of Hinduism
Ideal thesis	Hinduism has polytheistic forms, but "polytheistic" alone is philosophically inadequate because henotheistic, monotheistic, monistic and qualified-theistic structures coexist

Model answer

Hinduism is polytheistic at the level of ritual plurality: many deities have distinct names, forms, myths and devotional communities, and the Ṛgvedic pantheon is genuinely function-divided. But the criterion must be announced first - polytheism means plurality of **ultimates**, not of names, forms or access-points.

Three texts block the simple label. **Ṛgveda 1.164.46** says the one existent is spoken of variously by the wise, naming Indra, Mitra, Varuṇa and Agni as designations of a single referent. **Ṛgveda 10.129 (Nāsadiya)** resolves origins into "the One" and then doubts whether even the highest overseer knows. **Bṛhadāraṇyaka 3.9** reduces "three and three thousand" gods to one. Vedic religion is therefore better called **henotheistic** or **kathenotheistic** - F. Max Müller's terms for the pattern in which the invoked deity is addressed as supreme without the others being denied.

Devotional and philosophical structures reinforce this. The chosen deity (*iṣṭadevatā*), descent-forms (*avatāra*) and the Vaiṣṇava, Śaiva and Śākta theisms are each monotheistic in form. Advaita makes deities empirically valid but non-dual Brahman ultimate; Rāmānuja affirms one personal Brahman qualified by real selves and world; Nyāya posits one omniscient Īśvara as cosmic governor.

Hinduism therefore **contains** polytheism but is not reducible to it, and the category itself is imported from the Abrahamic dispute: plural practice coexists with contextual supremacy, sectarian one-God devotion and Upaniṣadic oneness.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** descriptive plurality -> classificatory distinctions -> school-wise evidence -> qualified verdict.
- **Doctrine:** polytheism, henotheism, kathenotheism, monotheism and monism.
- **Argument:** many forms do not by themselves prove many independent ultimate realities.
- **Technical terms:** *iṣṭa-devata*, Saguna Ishvara, Nirguna Brahman.
- **Comparison:** Vedic praise, bhakti supremacy, Advaita, Viśiṣṭadvaita and Nyaya.
- **Criticism/evaluation:** avoid imposing one Western category upon internally diverse traditions.
- **Conclusion:** "contains" polytheism but is not simply or uniformly polytheistic.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define polytheism; state qualified thesis
4 min : Ritual plurality + henotheism/kathenotheism
2 min : Advaita, Ramanuja, Nyaya
1 min : Reasoned verdict
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Calling Hinduism simply monotheistic because "truth is one": **erases real plurality**.
- Calling monism a form of monotheism: **category confusion**.
- Listing deities without philosophical classification: **descriptive, not analytical**.
- Claiming all deities are identical in every school: **historically and doctrinally false**.
- Giving a sociological answer without God-world metaphysics: **low optional value**.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"State and evaluate the personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	First state both models, then assess their philosophical adequacy
Core issue	Whether ultimacy is best conceived as purposive personality or transpersonal absolute
Scope boundary	Focus on the God-concept, not proofs of existence
Ideal thesis	Personalism secures religious relation; impersonalism secures infinity and non-anthropomorphism; neither is cost-free

Model answer

A **personalistic** conception attributes to God intelligence, will, purposive agency and relational capacities such as knowledge, love and response. Classical theism conceives God as a personal creator, while Rāmānuja's Brahman is the supreme personal Nārāyaṇa endowed with infinite auspicious qualities. Such a God makes prayer, providence, grace, command and moral accountability intelligible. "Personal," however, need not mean embodied or finite; divine personality is predicated **analogically**, so intelligence and love signify real perfections without univocal transfer from finite psychology.

An **impersonalistic** conception treats ultimate reality as exceeding person-like volition. Spinoza's *Deus sive Natura* is the one infinite substance from whose nature modes follow necessarily, and whose freedom is self-determination rather than choice. Śaṅkara's nirguṇa Brahman is non-dual reality beyond limiting predicates, reached by negation (*neti neti*, Brhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) and marked by the failure of objectifying speech ("whence words turn back", Taittirīya 2.9); saguṇa Īśvara belongs to the transactional standpoint. Impersonalism avoids anthropomorphism and preserves absoluteness, unity and necessity.

Both models face difficulties. Personalism risks projecting finite psychology upon infinity and must reconcile goodness with evil and changelessness with response. Impersonalism weakens petition, grace and moral address; Spinoza's God does not choose, while Advaita finally sublates the worshipper-worshipped distinction.

Advaita relates the two hierarchically by levels of truth, whereas Viśiṣṭādvaita makes personality ultimate and Rāmānuja objects that a wholly quality-less absolute is neither knowable nor worshippingable. Neither position can simply annex the other: adding will to an impersonal absolute changes its causal grammar, while stripping a personal God of agency destroys its religious function. A graded conclusion is preferable - personalism explains lived religion better, impersonalism guards transcendence better, and an adequate conception must show how personality can be perfect without becoming finite.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** precise definitions -> Western and Indian formulations -> strengths -> objections -> comparative verdict.
- **Doctrine:** classical theism, Spinoza, Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita.
- **Argument:** personality explains relation; impersonality explains absoluteness.
- **Technical terms:** analogical predication, *Deus sive Natura*, Nirguna, Saguna, *vyavaharika*, *paramarthika*.
- **Comparison:** do not equate Spinoza's substance with Advaita Brahman.
- **Criticism:** anthropomorphism versus religious remoteness.
- **Conclusion:** qualified, not an indiscriminate "both are true."

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Definitions and thesis
 5 min : Personalism - two traditions, strength, problem
 5 min : Impersonalism - two traditions, strength, problem
 1 min : Comparative verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Treating "personal" as physically human-shaped: **conceptual error**.
- Treating "impersonal" as unconscious matter: **serious distortion**.

- Writing only Saguna versus Nirguna: **insufficient Western coverage**.
- Claiming Advaita grants equal ultimacy to Ishvara and Nirguna Brahman: **wrong level distinction**.
- Ending with "both are complementary" without showing how: **unsupported synthesis**.

PYQ 3 - 2019, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the relationship between man and God according to any one of the religions in India."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain a relation systematically and evaluate its consequences
Core issue	Ontological, moral and soteriological relation between human self and God
Scope boundary	Choose one Indian religious-philosophical tradition and sustain it
Ideal thesis	In Ramanuja's Visishtadvaita, the jiva is real, distinct and responsible, yet inseparable from and wholly dependent upon God

Model answer

In Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita, the relation between man and God is neither numerical identity nor external dualism. Reality is one Brahman qualified by **cit**, conscious selves, and **acit**, non-conscious matter. The individual *jīva* is therefore a real and eternal mode or qualifier of Brahman, and the world is God's real transformation (*pariṇāma*) rather than an appearance.

Rāmānuja explains this through the **śarīra-śarīrī** relation. As a body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its indwelling self, so every *jīva* is the "body" of God, who is the inner controller (*antaryāmin*). The relation is **apṛthaksiddhi**: the self is distinct from God but cannot exist or be conceived independently of God. Hence the *jīva* is not Brahman, although it is inseparably dependent upon Brahman.

This ontology grounds religious life. The person remains a genuine knower, agent and bearer of karma; devotion is therefore not directed by an illusory self toward a provisional deity. Bondage contracts the self's manifested consciousness, while liberation expands it through knowledge, *bhakti*, self-surrender (*prapatti*) and divine grace. Liberation is loving communion and service, not the dissolution of individuality.

The body analogy preserves unity and difference, but raises the objection that embodied evil may implicate God. Rāmānuja distinguishes defects of the dependent body from the perfection of its controller, though divine responsibility remains a live pressure, and he adds that God consents to (*anumati*) rather than authors each finite act.

Other Indian options were available for this question - Śaiva Siddhānta's Lord, bound soul and threefold bond (*pati-paśu-pāśa*) with the five divine acts (*pañca-kṛtya*); Kashmir Śaivism's real self-manifestation (*ābhāsa*) through sovereign freedom (*svātantrya*), where liberation is recognition (*pratyabhijñā*); Śākta traditions in which divine power (*Śakti*) is the divine itself in dynamic aspect; or Madhva's independence-and-dependence axiom (*svatantra-paratantra*) with five eternal differences (*pañca-bheda*) and dependence-without-identity (*bimba-pratibimba*) - but the demand is to complete **one**. The relationship is best described as **distinct, dependent and inseparable communion**.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: school selection -> ontology -> relation -> moral agency -> liberation -> objection.
- **Doctrine**: Ishvara-cit-acit and qualified non-dualism.
- **Argument**: body criteria establish control, support and purposiveness.
- **Technical terms**: *śarīra-śarīrī*, *antaryāmin*, *apṛthak-siddhi*, *bhakti*, *prapatti*.
- **Comparison**: contrast with Advaita identity without drifting into a general Vedānta essay.
- **Criticism**: evil in God's body and divine responsibility.
- **Conclusion**: individuality survives dependence and liberation.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Select Ramanuja; state distinct-but-inseparable thesis
6 min : cit-acit + body relation + aprthak-siddhi
3 min : karma, bhakti, prapatti, moksha
2 min : objection, reply, verdict
Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying the jiva "is God" in Ramanuja: **major doctrinal error**.
- Using "body" literally or anthropomorphically: **misreads technical analogy**.
- Omitting soteriology: **relationship remains incomplete**.
- Treating *prapatti* as fatalistic passivity: **distorts agency and grace**.
- Comparing several religions despite "any one": **loss of depth and time**.

PYQ 4 - 2020, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact question

"Is there any compatibility between 'Freedom of Will' and 'Omnipotent God'? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Present incompatibilist pressure and a defensible reconciliation
Core issue	Whether maximal divine power excludes genuine creaturely agency
Scope boundary	Omnipotence is central; mention foreknowledge only as a connected but distinct problem
Ideal thesis	Compatibility is possible if omnipotence means power over all logically possible states and God voluntarily permits secondary agency

Model answer

Omnipotence should mean the power to actualize every logically possible state of affairs consistent with divine nature, not constant exercise of exhaustive control. Human freedom, minimally, requires that some actions issue from the agent rather than from external compulsion. On these definitions, compatibility is possible.

A creator may endow persons with **secondary causal agency** and refrain from determining each choice. Such self-restraint is an exercise of power: permission differs from inability to control. Moral responsibility presupposes this sphere.

The difficulty is sharper if freedom requires the categorical ability to do otherwise. An omnipotent God could override every choice; moreover, infallible divine foreknowledge appears to close alternatives. The standard reply distinguishes knowledge from causation and, on a timeless model, denies that God first predicts and then fixes the act. Yet non-causal certainty may still threaten alternative possibilities.

Thus omnipotence and agency are **conditionally compatible** if divine power can sustain non-coerced secondary causes. Libertarian freedom remains difficult when omniscience and providence are added.

Why this earns marks

- Definitions of coherent omnipotence and freedom.
- Distinction between **having power** and **exercising total control**.
- Voluntary divine self-limitation or secondary causation.
- Foreknowledge identified as distinct from causal determination.
- Objection concerning alternative possibilities.
- Qualified compatibility, not a simplistic harmony.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define both concepts
3 min : Compatibility through secondary causation
2 min : Foreknowledge/alternative-possibility objection
2 min : Reply and qualified verdict
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Defining omnipotence as ability to make contradictions true: **incoherent premise**.
- Equating God's knowledge with God's causation: **category error**.
- Saying self-restraint proves weakness: **ignores voluntary non-exercise**.
- Discussing only the problem of evil: **indirect answer**.
- Claiming complete resolution: **academically incautious**.

PYQ 5 - 2020, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the nature of God in Hinduism with special reference to Vishishtadvaita (Qualified non-dualism)."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Situate Hindu diversity, then give a full and evaluated Visishtadvaita account
Core issue	Nature, attributes and God-world-self relation in Ramanuja
Scope boundary	"Special reference" requires Ramanuja to dominate; other schools are contrasts
Ideal thesis	Ramanuja's God is the supreme personal Brahman whose unity is qualified by real cit and acit, preserving immanence, transcendence, causality and devotion

Model answer

Hinduism contains no single uncontested notion of God. Nyaya affirms an omniscient efficient cause; Advaita makes Nirguna Brahman ultimate and Saguna Ishvara empirically valid; bhakti traditions affirm a supreme personal deity. Ramanuja's **Visishtadvaita** offers a distinctive synthesis: non-duality without erasing real plurality.

Brahman is Narayana, the supreme personal reality endowed with infinite auspicious qualities (*ananta-kalyana-guna*). "Saguna" here does not mean limited by accidental properties; divine attributes express perfection. Reality comprises **Ishvara, cit** and **acit**. Selves and matter are real but not independent substances. They qualify Brahman, forming one organic whole. Hence the system is "qualified non-dualism."

The central model is **sarira-sariri-bhava**. Cit and acit constitute God's body; God is their indwelling Self or *antaryamin*. A body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its self. This does not give God a finite physical organism. It expresses complete dependence and governance. Through **aprthak-siddhi**, jivas and world are distinct yet inseparable from Brahman; a jiva never becomes numerically identical with the whole God.

God is both **efficient cause**, as intelligent director, and **material cause**, because subtle cit-acit inseparably belonging to Brahman becomes manifest as the cosmos. Unlike Advaita's *vivarta*, the world is real. Change occurs in dependent acit, not in God's essential perfection. Thus God is immanent as inner controller and transcendent because divine reality exceeds every finite mode.

This metaphysics grounds religion. Jivas remain agents and bearers of karma; liberation preserves individuality. Knowledge culminates in *bhakti*, while *prapatti* expresses complete surrender to grace. Moksha is communion and service, not absorption.

Two pressures remain. If suffering occurs in God's body, divine perfection and responsibility seem threatened. Ramanuja replies that defects qualify the controlled body, not the controller's essence, though complete governance keeps the problem alive. Further, critics may find organic unity insufficiently distinct from panentheism; nevertheless, Ramanuja's specifically theistic framework includes purposive personality, grace and real difference.

Visishtadvaita therefore presents God as a **personal, immanent-transcendent, qualified unity**: neither an impersonal absolute nor one being externally alongside the world, but the independent whole in whom real selves and nature exist inseparably.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: Hindu plurality -> attributes -> Ishvara-cit-acit -> body relation -> causation -> salvation -> critique.
- **Doctrine**: personal Narayana with infinite auspicious qualities.
- **Argument**: organic unity reconciles scriptural unity and plurality.
- **Technical terms**: *ananta-kalyana-guna, antaryamin, sarira-sariri, aprthak-siddhi, parinama, bhakti, prapatti*.
- **Comparison**: Advaita's *vivarta* and Nyaya's merely efficient causation.
- **Criticism/reply**: evil in God's body; change and divine perfection.
- **Conclusion**: qualified unity preserves real plurality and personal theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Hindu plurality + Ramanuja thesis
 7 min : Attributes, cit-acit, body relation, aprthak-siddhi
 4 min : Material/efficient cause + immanence/transcendence
 3 min : Jiva, bhakti, prapatti, moksha
 2 min : Two criticisms, reply, verdict
 Total : 18 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Making the answer a generic survey of Hindu gods: **ignores special reference**.
- Calling cit and acit independent substances: **breaks qualified non-dualism**.
- Equating *aprthak-siddhi* with identity: **central doctrinal failure**.
- Saying God's essence literally becomes evil matter: **misstates causation**.
- Omitting grace and liberation: **incomplete God-human relation**.
- Calling the world *mithya*: **imports Advaita into Ramanuja**.

PYQ 6 - 2021, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the nature of God as propounded in Nyāya philosophy."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain attributes and systematic role; briefly assess
Core issue	Nyaya Ishvara within pluralist realism
Scope boundary	Nature of God, not a catalogue of Udayana's proofs
Ideal thesis	God is an eternal omniscient special self and efficient cause who orders atoms and administers karma, but is not the material cause

Model answer

Nyāya conceives Īśvara within a **pluralist realist** ontology in which atoms, selves, space and time are also real. Īśvara is one eternal, omniscient and incorporeal **special self**, never bound by karma, ignorance or bodily limitation; his agency is volitional rather than physical.

His principal cosmological role is that of **nimitta-kāraṇa**, the intelligent efficient cause. Eternal atoms remain the material cause. At creation God initiates and coordinates atomic combinations; he sustains cosmic order and governs dissolution. Nyāya therefore accepts neither creation from nothing nor the Vedāntic claim that God is also the material cause.

Īśvara also administers unseen moral potency (*adṛṣṭa*): karma supplies the basis of consequences, while God allots their fruits in accordance with desert, so human effort (*puruṣakāra*) is preserved. Later Nyāya treats him as the

authoritative author of the Veda.

Critics argue that eternal atoms and karma together make God redundant. Nyāya replies that unconscious atoms and unconscious merit cannot intelligently order themselves. The view secures causal and moral governance, though the necessity of an infinite governor remains contestable - and the existence inferences belong to the proofs topic, not to this profile.

Why this earns marks

- Nyaya's pluralist-realist background.
- God as eternal omniscient special self.
- **Efficient, not material, cause.**
- Atoms, cosmic arrangement, karma and Vedic authorship.
- One relevant proof only as support, not as the whole answer.
- Redundancy objection and Nyaya reply.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Pluralist context
4 min : Attributes + efficient causation + atoms
2 min : Karma and Veda
1 min : Objection and verdict
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Making God the material cause: **decisive factual error**.
- Saying atoms are created by God: **misstates classical atomism**.
- Listing eight proofs without explaining divine nature: **fails directive**.
- Treating karma as a conscious allocator: **category mistake**.
- Identifying Nyaya Ishvara with Nirguna Brahman: **cross-school conflation**.

PYQ 7 - 2022, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

"Write an essay on Spinoza's notion of God and His attributes."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Give a compact connected exposition, not disconnected definitions
Core issue	God as the one substance expressed through attributes
Scope boundary	Explain substance-attribute-mode sufficiently; avoid a biography of Spinoza
Ideal thesis	God is not a personal creator but the absolutely infinite immanent substance whose essence is expressed through infinite attributes

Model answer

Spinoza rejects the creator-creation dualism of classical theism. God is **the one absolutely infinite substance**, expressed by *Deus sive Natura* - "God, or Nature." Substance exists in itself and is conceived through itself; because an infinite substance excludes any rival of the same attribute, only God possesses full ontological independence.

An **attribute** is what intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. God has infinitely many attributes, although humans know **Thought** and **Extension**. These are not two substances; each expresses the same divine reality. Minds, bodies and events are dependent **modes**. No finite mode is the whole God.

God is immanent, not a transcendent craftsman. *Natura naturans* is active self-caused nature; *natura naturata* is the necessary modal order. God does not deliberate among possible worlds. Freedom means acting from one's own nature without external constraint.

This secures unity and necessity but abandons personal providence and libertarian choice. Spinoza's God is metaphysically supreme, though not the personal deity of classical religion.

Why this earns marks

- *Deus sive Natura* and one-substance thesis.
- Exact definitions of substance, attribute and mode.
- Thought and Extension as known attributes.
- Immanent causation, necessity and Spinozistic freedom.
- *Natura naturans/naturata* if space permits.
- Criticism: loss of personality and providence.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Thesis - God/Nature as one substance
 4 min : Substance -> attributes -> modes
 2 min : Immanence, necessity, freedom
 1 min : Criticism and verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying God is the sum of finite objects: **reduces substance to aggregate**.
- Treating attributes as modes: **basic architecture confused**.
- Saying each mode is independently the whole God: **false identity claim**.
- Describing Spinoza as a deist: **opposite God-world relation**.
- Attributing deliberative creation or miracles to God: **contradicts necessity**.

PYQ 8 - 2022, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Explain the relation between the God and the Self according to Rāmānujācārya."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain the exact metaphysical relation and its consequences
Core issue	How real distinction coexists with inseparability
Scope boundary	God-self relation; world may clarify the system but must not dominate
Ideal thesis	The jīva is a real conscious mode and body of Brahman: different, dependent and inseparable, never numerically identical

Model answer

For Rāmānuja, God is the supreme personal Brahman, while the individual self is a real, eternal and conscious *jīva*. Their relation avoids both non-dual identity and an external dualism of independent substances. Brahman is one organic whole qualified by **cit**, the plurality of selves, and **acit**, matter, and the world is its real transformation (*pariṇāma*).

The decisive concept is **apṛthaksiddhi**, inseparable existence. The self is a genuine qualifier or mode (*prakāra*) of Brahman. It is numerically distinct and morally responsible, yet it cannot exist or be understood independently of God. Rāmānuja further expresses this through **śarīra-śarīrī-bhāva**: the *jīva* is God's body, while God is its indwelling Self (*antaryāmin*). A body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its self. "Body" therefore indicates metaphysical dependence, not divine physical anatomy.

This relation explains both agency and devotion. The *jīva* knows, acts and bears karma; God is the inner governor and gracious end of action, sustaining the capacity to act and consenting (*anumati*) to its exercise, so moral authorship remains the *jīva*'s. Bondage obscures the full manifestation of the self's consciousness but does not make individuality illusory. Through right knowledge, disciplined action, *bhakti* and *prapatti*, the *jīva* receives grace, and in liberation

enjoys communion and service while retaining its identity.

Two contrasts sharpen the account. Against Śaṅkara, the self is not Brahman but belongs to Brahman; against Madhva, whose reflection relation (*bimba-pratibimba*) keeps five eternal differences, Rāmānuja's dependence is internal to one qualified whole. The model preserves unity, religious relation and plurality better than numerical identity, yet if every suffering self is God's body under divine control, responsibility for evil remains a serious pressure. The relation is best formulated as **real distinction within complete, purposive dependence**.

Why this earns marks

- Ishvara and cit within the qualified whole.
- *Aprthak-siddhi* precisely distinguished from identity.
- *Prakara*, *sarira-sariri* and *antaryamin*.
- Moral agency, karma and liberation.
- Bhakti, prapatti and grace.
- Advaita contrast and evil/body objection.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Qualified non-dual setting
6 min : aprthak-siddhi + mode + body relation
3 min : agency, karma and liberation
2 min : Advaita contrast + evil objection + verdict
Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "self is identical with Brahman": **replaces Ramanuja with Sankara**.
- Treating the self as independently substantial: **loses inseparability**.
- Treating body-language physically: **misses technical definition**.
- Omitting retained individuality in moksha: **incomplete soteriology**.
- Saying grace cancels action and responsibility: **false fatalism**.

PYQ 9 - 2022, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Critically examine the idea of Brahman in Advaita philosophy of Śaṅkara. Does Śaṅkara's conception of Brahman leave room for theism? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Expose the doctrine, criticize it, and answer the explicit theism question
Core issue	Relation between Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Ishvara
Scope boundary	Brahman and theism, not a general account of all Advaita categories
Ideal thesis	Sankara permits genuine empirical theism but ultimately sublates personal creator-creature duality

Model answer

Śaṅkara's Advaita identifies **nirguṇa Brahman** as the sole ultimate (*pāramārthika*) reality: non-dual, self-revealing consciousness beyond limiting, relational predicates. *Sat-cit-ānanda* does not add three properties to Brahman; these are its essential nature-defining marks (*svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*), as against the relational definition of Brahman as world-cause (*taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*, "that from which arises the origin of this"). *Neti neti* (Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) removes objectifying descriptions rather than reducing Brahman to nothing, and Taittirīya 2.9 marks the failure of speech, not the absence of reality.

The experienced plurality of self, world and deity is explained through *māyā* and superimposition (*adhyāsa*). The world is dependent and sublatale, not sheer non-being; it is the world-appearance, not Brahman, that is properly called indeterminable (*anirvacanīya*). Brahman does not really transform: the world is apparent transformation (*vivarta*), as a

snake appears on a rope. Viewed in relation to *māyā*, Brahman is **saguṇa Īśvara**, omniscient creator, moral governor and object of worship at the transactional (*vyāvahārika*) level.

This clearly leaves room for theism. Devotion, meditation, scripture and divine governance possess genuine empirical validity and purify the mind for liberating knowledge. Yet the room is **provisional**, because knowledge finally sublates the distinction among worshipper, worshipped and world; ultimate Brahman is neither a person alongside persons nor a creator in an unsublatable relation.

Rāmānuja objects that a quality-less absolute is unintelligible and demotes religion, since what is wholly undetermined is neither knowable, nameable nor worshipping. Advaita replies that finite predicates limit ultimacy and that negation removes superimposition, not reality. The reply preserves absoluteness but leaves positive intelligibility and the final status of devotion under pressure.

Therefore Śaṅkara is neither a straightforward theist nor an atheist: Advaita validates **empirical theism as path** while transcending it in non-dual realisation as goal.

Why this earns marks

- Nirguna Brahman as non-dual and non-objectifiable.
- *Sat-cit-ananda* and *neti neti* correctly interpreted.
- Maya, adhyasa, mithya and vivarta in supporting roles.
- Saguna Ishvara at *vyavaharika* level.
- Explicit "yes, but provisionally" answer.
- Ramanuja's objection, Advaita reply and graded conclusion.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Define Nirguna Brahman
 5 min : sat-cit-ananda, neti neti, maya, mithya, vivarta
 3 min : Saguna Ishvara and case for theism
 2 min : provisionality + Ramanuja objection/reply
 1 min : Explicit verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying Nirguna means "without any reality or nature": **nihilistic misreading**.
- Calling the world *tuccha* or absolutely unreal: **wrong status**.
- Treating Ishvara as useless illusion: **ignores empirical validity**.
- Saying Advaita is unqualified personal theism: **ignores sublation**.
- Discussing maya at length without answering theism: **fails second half**.

PYQ 10 - 2023, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

"Elucidate the personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Clarify the distinction with revealing examples
Core issue	Relational agency versus transpersonal ultimacy
Scope boundary	Concise conceptual exposition; evaluation must be controlled
Ideal thesis	The contrast concerns the grammar of ultimacy, not bodily versus non-bodily existence

Model answer

The **personalistic** aspect conceives God as possessing intellect, will, purpose and the capacity for relation. Classical theism's creator and Ramanuja's Saguna Brahman know, govern, love and respond. This makes prayer, revelation, moral command, grace and providence intelligible. Personality, however, is predicated analogically; it does not imply a finite body or changing human psychology.

The **impersonalistic** aspect conceives ultimate reality as beyond person-like volition. Spinoza's God is the one infinite substance whose modes follow necessarily, not a deity choosing among worlds. Sankara's Nirguna Brahman transcends limiting predicates; Saguna Ishvara and devotion are valid empirically, while ultimate realization sublates subject-object duality.

Personalism risks anthropomorphism and faces the problem of reconciling immutable perfection with response and worldly evil. Impersonalism protects infinity, unity and necessity, but weakens reciprocal worship, providence and moral address.

The alternatives need not be mechanically combined. Advaita orders them as empirical and ultimate; Visishtadvaita rejects this hierarchy and makes divine personality supreme. Thus the issue is whether ultimacy is best understood as perfect agency or transpersonal ground.

Why this earns marks

- Clear definitions without "personal = physical."
- One Western and one Indian example for each side.
- Religious strength of personalism.
- Metaphysical strength of impersonalism.
- One problem for each.
- Advaita/Visishtadvaita contrast and a precise final question.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define contrast
3 min : Personalistic examples and evaluation
3 min : Impersonalistic examples and evaluation
1 min : Advaita/Ramanuja verdict
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Reproducing the 2019 answer at 15-mark length: **poor time discipline**.
- Equating impersonal with morally evil: **non sequitur**.
- Calling Spinoza's God mere matter: **reductive error**.
- Treating Saguna and Nirguna as two independent Gods: **Advaita distorted**.
- Giving examples without elucidating the distinction: **under-analysis**.

PYQ 11 - 2023, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"In what sense is God both immanent and transcendent in theism? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain the precise senses in which both predicates coexist and test the synthesis
Core issue	Divine presence without reduction; divine independence without remoteness
Scope boundary	Theism is primary; pantheism and deism are contrasts
Ideal thesis	God is transcendent as ontologically independent creator and immanent as sustaining ground and active presence

Model answer

In theism, **transcendence** does not mean spatial distance. It means that God is ontologically independent of the world, not one finite item within it and not exhausted by cosmic processes. As creator, God is the source of the world's being and value. **Immanence** means that this transcendent source remains present and operative as sustainer, governor and ground of every creature's continued existence - the scriptural inner controller (*antaryāmin*) rather than a physical constituent.

Classical theism combines them through creation and conservation. God is distinct from secondary causes but does not compete with them as another worldly cause: on the Thomist account of primary and secondary causation, divine causation enables creaturely activity instead of displacing it. This avoids deism, where the creator becomes religiously remote, and pantheism, where the distinction between God and nature disappears. Creation from nothing states the same point ontologically - no independent material co-principle, and dependence at every moment rather than only at a first instant.

Rāmānuja gives a stronger model of immanence. The world and selves are God's body, while God is their indwelling Self. Through **apṛthaksiddhi** they are inseparable from Brahman, yet Brahman exceeds every finite mode; so God indwells without numerical identity. Panentheistic language - world in God, God more than world - is suggestive, though Rāmānuja's purposive body relation is more specific and process versions revise power and changelessness in ways classical theism refuses.

The synthesis faces tensions. If God is wholly changeless and non-composite, genuine responsiveness appears difficult; if immanence is intensified, transcendence may collapse into pantheism; and excessive transcendence weakens providence. Theism's coherent claim is therefore relational: God is **non-dependent yet universally sustaining**, present through causation and governance rather than physical location. Both predicates are necessary to preserve divine ultimacy together with religious accessibility.

Why this earns marks

- Non-spatial definitions of both terms.
- Creation/conservation and primary-secondary causation.
- Deism and pantheism as nearest one-sided contrasts.
- Ramanuja's *antaryāmin* and body relation.
- Caution regarding panentheism.
- Immutability/response and collapse/remoteness objections.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Define both terms non-spatially
5 min : Classical theistic synthesis
3 min : Ramanuja as Indian model
2 min : Two-sided danger and verdict
Total : 12-13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Transcendence = "God lives far above": **spatializes ontology**.
- Immanence = "every object is the whole God": **confuses pantheism**.
- Writing only panentheism: **misses theistic framework**.
- Claiming immanence requires a divine body: **unjustified**.
- Merely saying "God is both": **no explanatory mechanism**.

PYQ 12 - 2024, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"How does the notion of God in Spinoza's philosophy embedded in his metaphysics of substance and attributes? Critically discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Derive the God-concept from the metaphysical architecture and criticize it
Core issue	Why God cannot be separated from substance, attributes and modes
Scope boundary	Do not give a free-standing theology or only repeat <i>Deus sive Natura</i>
Ideal thesis	Spinoza's God is the necessary consequence of substance monism: infinite substance expressed through attributes and modified as modes

Model answer

Spinoza's God is not appended to his metaphysics; God **is its sole substance**. Substance is "in itself and conceived through itself," whereas a mode exists in and is conceived through another. Since distinct substances cannot share an attribute and absolutely infinite substance possesses infinite attributes, no rival substance can exist. Hence *Deus sive Natura*: God or Nature is the one self-caused, necessary reality.

An **attribute** is what intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. God has infinitely many attributes; finite human cognition knows Thought and Extension. They are not independent mental and material substances, but complete expressions of one divine essence. Particular minds and bodies are **modes** under these attributes. Modes depend upon God, but neither an individual mode nor the collection of finite things is independently identical with the whole infinite substance.

This architecture determines the divine profile. God is immanent cause: things exist in God and follow necessarily from divine nature. *Natura naturans* denotes active, self-caused nature; *natura naturata* the order of modes. God does not create through deliberative will. Freedom means determination by one's own nature without external constraint, not choice among alternatives.

The system secures unity and non-anthropomorphic ultimacy. Yet conceptual self-dependence may not prove ontological existence, and the transition from infinite attributes to finite modes remains obscure. Necessary expression also removes providence, petitionary relation and libertarian freedom.

Thus Spinoza offers a rigorous metaphysical Absolute rather than the personal God of classical theism. His God is intelligible only through the sequence **substance -> attributes -> modes -> necessary immanence**.

Why this earns marks

- Derivation from the definition and uniqueness of substance.
- Attribute as essence-expression, not detachable quality.
- Thought and Extension without Cartesian dualism.
- Modes as dependent modifications, not independent pieces of God.
- *Natura naturans/naturata*, immanent cause and necessity.
- Critique of derivation, mode-production, personality and freedom.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Substance definition and monism
5 min : Attributes and modes
3 min : Immanent cause, necessity, freedom
2 min : Two metaphysical + one religious criticism
1 min : Embedded-architecture verdict
Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Giving only "God = Nature": **fails "embedded in metaphysics"**.

- Calling modes parts that compose substance: **incorrect dependence model**.
- Saying Thought and Extension are the only divine attributes: **humans know them; God has infinitely many**.
- Making Spinoza's God a chooser: **contradicts necessity**.
- Labelling the system atheism without argument: **polemical, not critical**.

PYQ 13 - 2024, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"In order to be conceived as the ultimate cause of the world, God must necessarily have some form of physical manifestation." Do you agree with this view? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Test a necessity claim and justify agreement or disagreement
Core issue	Whether causal ultimacy requires embodiment or physical manifestation
Scope boundary	Distinguish manifestation, incarnation, material cause, body relation and efficient cause
Ideal thesis	Physical manifestation may mediate religious knowledge, but is not conceptually necessary for metaphysical causation

Model answer

The claim gains plausibility from ordinary causation: causes are encountered through effects, embodied agency or observable interaction. Religious incarnation and symbolism also make divine action accessible. However, this supports an **epistemic need for manifestation**, not the stronger ontological thesis that an ultimate cause must itself be physical.

A physical entity is spatially located, divisible, changeable and dependent upon physical conditions. If God is the ultimate cause of the whole physical order, making God one physical member of that order risks explanatory circularity. Classical theism therefore treats God as the non-physical primary cause who creates and sustains secondary causes. Causal dependence need not involve physical contact or similarity between cause and effect.

Indian systems reinforce the distinction. Nyaya's Ishvara is the intelligent **efficient cause** ordering eternal atoms; God is not an atom or the material cause. Advaita's Brahman is the non-objectifiable ground upon which the world appears through *vivarta*, while Saguna Ishvara governs empirical causation. Ramanuja calls world and selves God's "body," but *sarira-sariri* denotes control, support and purposive dependence, not an anthropomorphic organism. Spinoza identifies God with infinite Nature, yet even here no finite body is the whole divine substance.

One may object that an unmanifest cause is unverifiable. Yet effects or order may disclose a cause inferentially; evidence of a cause is not its physical embodiment. Whether such inferences succeed is separate.

I therefore disagree with the stated necessity. Physical manifestation is possible within some religious models and may aid devotion, but **ultimate causation requires explanatory independence and adequate causal power, not bodily form**.

Why this earns marks

- Immediate distinction between epistemic manifestation and ontological embodiment.
- Why physicality may conflict with ultimacy.
- Classical primary/secondary causation.
- Nyaya efficient cause, Advaita appearance, Ramanuja body relation and Spinoza qualification.
- Explicit distinction among identity, embodiment, appearance and causation.
- Objection concerning verifiability and a direct verdict.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Clarify five key terms; state disagreement
 4 min : Argument from physical limitation and primary causation
 4 min : Nyaya, Advaita, Ramanuja, Spinoza
 2 min : Verifiability objection/reply
 1 min : Explicit justified verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Assuming all causes must physically resemble effects: **unsupported analogy**.
- Treating Ramanuja's divine body as a giant organism: **technical error**.
- Saying Nyaya God supplies the atoms: **confuses efficient/material cause**.
- Equating incarnation with metaphysical causation: **scope confusion**.
- Giving several doctrines but no agreement/disagreement: **fails directive**.

Comparative Essay Matrix

Original deterministic study visual

Ontology	World relation	Human relation	Evaluation
Person, substance, pure act, absolute Necessary or contingent One, many or non-dual	Creation, emanation, identity, inclusion Transcendence and immanence Providence and agency	Prayer, grace, command, bhakti Freedom and responsibility Salvation or liberation	Coherence Anthropomorphism Evil, hiddenness and language

Compare positions on common dimensions; do not classify by labels alone.

Comparative essay and practice matrix

Use the matrix before every comparative answer. First hold the axis constant: compare ontology with ontology, world relation with world relation, and soteriology with soteriology. Then add one model-specific objection and reply. This prevents the common error of contrasting, for example, Spinoza's ontology with Ramanuja's devotional practice without explaining the intermediate metaphysical relation.

Six original questions, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, written in the style and directive vocabulary of Philosophy Paper II. They are learner practice, not previous-year questions, and no model answer below is an official UPSC key. The working bands used throughout this package are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**; demand decoding and the "why this earns marks" notes sit outside the timed count.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish between the transcendence and the immanence of God, and explain why classical theism must assert both. (10 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Distinguish... and explain" - two definitions, then a reason for holding them jointly
Core issue	Whether the two attributes are rivals or joint requirements of one God-concept
Scope boundary	Ten marks: two definitions, one joint argument, one contrast, one verdict - not a survey of models
Non-negotiables	Non-spatial reading of both terms; the cost of asserting either alone

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Transcendence and immanence are not two degrees of divine presence but two different relations, and classical theism asserts both because each alone destroys something the concept requires.

Transcendence. FACT: Transcendence is ontological independence: God's being is not derived from, exhausted by or constrained by the world. It is not spatial remoteness, since a merely distant God would still be one item inside the same order of being.

Immanence. FACT: Immanence is sustaining presence and activity: creaturely being depends on God at every moment, and secondary natural causes operate through that primary dependence rather than in competition with it. It is not physical inclusion, which would make God a part of the world.

Why both. ANALYSIS: Pure transcendence yields the deist's absentee, for whom providence, grace and address become unintelligible. Pure immanence yields identity with nature, so no independent standard remains by which the world could be judged or redeemed. FACT: Rāmānuja secures the same joint result by a different route: world and selves are God's real body, so the indwelling controller is genuinely present yet never reducible to the controlled.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The two are compatible once both are read as relations of dependence rather than of distance, and classical theism needs their conjunction to keep both worship and explanation available.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** joint thesis -> each term defined negatively and positively -> cost of each alone -> Indian parallel -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** ontological independence; primary and secondary causation; body-and-self relation (*śarīra-śarīrī*).
- **Evidence:** the deist absentee; the pantheist identity; Rāmānuja's indwelling controller.
- **Distinction:** dependence against distance - the discriminating move most scripts miss.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: Does the doctrine of divine simplicity strengthen or weaken the notion of a personal God? Give reasons for your answer. (10 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Does... give reasons" - a defended verdict, with reasons ranked
Core issue	Whether denying composition in God is compatible with agency, knowledge and love
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the doctrine, one strengthening reason, two costs, one graded verdict
Non-negotiables	Simplicity stated as a denial of composition; modal collapse and the property objection named

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Non-composition (divine simplicity) strengthens the *metaphysics* of a personal God and weakens its *religious grammar*; the verdict must therefore be graded rather than flat.

The doctrine. FACT: Simplicity denies every composition in God - matter and form, substance and accident, essence and existence - so that wisdom, goodness and power name one identical reality under different creaturely modes of conception. Aseity, the claim that God derives nothing, is its close companion.

The strengthening reason. ANALYSIS: Whatever is composite depends on its parts and on whatever unites them; a first, underived ground cannot be dependent. Simplicity therefore secures precisely the non-derivation that makes God worth calling ultimate rather than merely greatest.

The costs. CAUTION: Two objections bite. **Modal collapse:** if God is identical with the divine act of will and exists necessarily, whatever is willed appears necessary, so creation loses contingency. FACT: **Plantinga's objection** in *Does God Have a Nature?* presses that if God is identical with a property, then God is a property, and no property is an agent who knows or loves.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Simplicity is defensible only when identity is read analogically or as a truthmaker claim; on that reading it protects ultimacy, but it narrows what the believer originally wanted to assert about response and relation. That narrowing is the real cost.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** graded thesis -> doctrine -> argument for it -> two named objections -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** composition, essence and existence, aseity, analogical identity.
- **Evidence:** the dependence argument; modal collapse; Plantinga's property objection.
- **Qualification:** the verdict concedes a cost instead of declaring the doctrine simply true or false.

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Examine whether a quality-transcending absolute can perform the religious functions performed by a personal God. (15 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine" - reconstruct, test, and deliver a reasoned judgement
Core issue	Whether worship, prayer, grace and moral address survive the removal of personality
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the functions named, both sides at full strength, one worked objection and reply, a conditional verdict
Non-negotiables	Two levels of truth; negation as removal of limits; Rāmānuja's counter-case

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: A quality-transcending absolute can perform the *contemplative* religious functions completely and the *dialogical* ones only by relocating them to a lower level; whether that relocation is a solution or a concession is the point at issue.

The functions in question. FACT: A personal God supports petition, providence, grace, command, forgiveness and covenantal address, because knowing, willing and loving are predicated of it - analogically, not univocally.

The Advaita reply. FACT: Śaṅkara does not abolish these functions; he assigns them to the personal Lord (*Īśvara*), Brahman understood through the cosmic power of appearance at the transactional level (*vyāvahārika*), while quality-transcending Brahman is ultimate (*pāramārthika*). FACT: Negation (*neti neti*, Brhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 2.3.6) removes limiting predicates, not reality; Brahman remains being, consciousness and bliss as its essential nature.

What the absolute does better. ANALYSIS: It secures non-anthropomorphic ultimacy and unity, and it disarms the objection that finite psychology has been projected upward. Contemplative realisation - the recognition of an identity never actually lost - needs no responsive interlocutor at all.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Rāmānuja objects that an entity with no determinations whatever is neither knowable, nameable nor worshippingable, so Brahman must be qualified (*saviśeṣa*). ANALYSIS: The Advaitin replies that what is denied is limitation, not determinacy as such, and that devotion is genuinely valid at its own level. The residual difficulty is that the worshipper's standpoint is finally sublated, so devotion is preserved as provisional rather than ultimate.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: On a contemplative criterion the absolute performs every function; on a relational criterion it performs them only at a level it also cancels. The honest conclusion states the criterion first and then the cost.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** functions named -> the level solution -> its advantages -> objection and reply -> criterion-relative verdict.
- **Doctrine:** two standpoints; apophatic negation; qualification (*saviśeṣa*) as the rival demand.
- **Evidence:** *neti neti* with its Upaniṣadic reference; being-consciousness-bliss as essential nature; Rāmānuja's unknowability argument.
- **Qualification:** the verdict is conditional on the criterion, which is what "examine" demands.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: Critically examine the claim that the divine attributes form a single package whose members constrain one another. (15 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically examine" - reconstruct the claim, test it, and grade it
Core issue	Whether the attributes are an additive list or a mutually constraining system
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: three worked constraints, one reply each, one verdict
Non-negotiables	At least three named tensions; the specification move; the cost of each repair

Independent model answer

Thesis. FACT: The attributes are a package rather than a list: each is stated in a way that limits how the others may be stated, and the standard defences work by *specifying* terms rather than by adding new ones.

Constraint one - power and possibility. FACT: Omnipotence must be restricted to the absolutely possible, since a contradictory description names no object of power (Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I q.25 a.3). **ANALYSIS:** The restriction protects goodness too, because impeccability then counts as a perfection rather than a deficiency of power.

Constraint two - knowledge and freedom. FACT: Exhaustive foreknowledge plus the fixity of the past threatens libertarian alternatives. The four standard exits - timeless eternity, soft facts about the past, middle knowledge (*scientia media*), and open theism - each pay a different price, from contested metaphysics to the grounding objection to an amended omniscience.

Constraint three - changelessness and personality. CAUTION: Knowledge, love and response look personal only if God stands in real changing relations, yet changelessness denies intrinsic change. The distinction between intrinsic change and new relations or effects is the standard repair, and it remains disputed.

The systemic point. ANALYSIS: Non-composition tightens the package further: if the attributes are one reality diversely signified, no attribute can be traded off against another, which is why modal collapse and the property objection are so damaging.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The claim survives. Each attribute is coherent once specified, but every specification narrows what the religious believer originally wanted to assert - and the cumulative narrowing, not any single paradox, is the strongest objection to the classical package.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** thesis -> three constraints, each with its repair -> the simplicity multiplier -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** absolute possibility, accidental necessity, middle knowledge, intrinsic change and relation, non-composition.
- **Evidence:** the Thomist restriction with its reference; the four named exits; the modal-collapse objection.
- **Analysis:** the verdict identifies a cumulative cost rather than scoring one paradox.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: Compare the God-world-human relation in Spinoza, Śaṅkara and Rāmānuja, and assess which model best preserves both metaphysical ultimacy and religious life. (20 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Compare... and assess" - a common axis, then a graded judgement
Core issue	Whether ultimacy and religious life can be secured by one model at once
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: three systems on the same axes, one objection each, one criterion-based verdict
Non-negotiables	Same axes for all three; no equation of substance with Brahman; a stated criterion before the verdict

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Judged by metaphysical economy Spinoza wins, by non-anthropomorphic ultimacy Śaṅkara wins, and by religious adequacy Rāmānuja wins; so the assessment must name its criterion before it names a winner.

The common axes. ANALYSIS: Three questions discipline the comparison: what is the world's ontological status, what is the human self, and what religious relation remains available?

Spinoza. FACT: There is one infinite substance, God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*), expressed through infinitely many attributes, of which we know Thought and Extension; finite minds and bodies are modes. FACT: God is the immanent, not the transitive, cause, and acts from the necessity of the divine nature, so freedom means self-determination rather than choice. ANALYSIS: Religious life becomes the intellectual love of God - understanding the necessary whole - while petition and grace disappear.

Śaṅkara. FACT: Brahman alone is real; the world is apparent transformation (*vivarta*), empirically available but sublatale; the self is not a part or mode but Brahman itself. FACT: The personal Lord is Brahman at the transactional level, so worship is valid but not final. ANALYSIS: Ultimacy is protected at the cost of making the worshipper's standpoint provisional.

Rāmānuja. FACT: Brahman is a qualified unity whose body is the real plurality of selves (*cit*) and matter (*acit*), related by inseparability (*apṛthaksiddhi*); the world is real transformation (*pariṇāma*), and God is both material and efficient cause. FACT: Selves remain eternally real, so devotion and surrender are ultimate rather than provisional. CAUTION: The objection is that defect in the body should infect the indwelling self; the reply distinguishes the controller's perfection from the condition of what is controlled.

Assessment. ANALYSIS: If the criterion is parsimony, one substance with modes is unbeatable - but it abolishes address. If the criterion is freedom from anthropomorphism, non-dualism is strongest - but it sublates the devotee. If the criterion is the intelligibility of worship, qualified non-dualism is strongest - but it must keep answering the defect objection.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: No model secures both goods without remainder; Rāmānuja pays the smallest religious price, and Śaṅkara the smallest anthropomorphic one.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** criterion-flagging thesis -> shared axes -> three systems in identical order -> assessment by criterion -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** substance and mode; apparent against real transformation; inseparability without identity.
- **Evidence:** *Deus sive Natura*; the immanent-cause claim; the two levels of truth; body-and-self relation; the defect objection and its reply.
- **Distinction:** the refusal to equate Spinoza's substance with non-dual Brahman, which is the fault line examiners test.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: Can an Indian system that denies a creator God still offer a complete notion of ultimacy? Discuss with reference to at least three systems. (20 marks)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Can... discuss" - a defended yes/no with at least three named systems
Core issue	Whether creation is necessary for ultimacy, or whether other functions can carry it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: three or four systems, the functions of ultimacy, one objection, one verdict
Non-negotiables	"Non-theistic" is not "irreligious"; each system's own ultimate must be named

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: Yes, provided "ultimacy" is analysed by function rather than assumed to mean creatorship: the functions of grounding, ordering, explaining bondage and securing liberation can be discharged without a maker of the world.

What ultimacy is being asked to do. ANALYSIS: A notion of ultimacy must supply a terminus of dependence or explanation, an account of moral order, and a criterion of the highest human good. Creation is one way of discharging the first function, not the only way.

Mīmāṃsā. FACT: The eternal Veda, ritual order and unseen potency require no divine author; injunctive language and the moral economy of action carry the weight that a creator carries elsewhere. ANALYSIS: Ultimacy here is normative rather than personal.

Sāṃkhya. FACT: Conscious selves and primordial nature are independent principles; evolution proceeds without a divine orderer, and liberation is the discriminative knowledge that separates the self from nature. ANALYSIS: The terminus of explanation is a duality of principles rather than a single creator.

Classical Yoga. FACT: The special self (*puruṣa-viśeṣa*) is untouched by affliction and karma and functions as the archetypal teacher and object of devoted attention, not as the maker of nature's evolution. ANALYSIS: This shows that a God-concept can be religiously central while being cosmologically inert.

Buddhism and Jainism. FACT: Both reject an omnipotent creator while retaining a complete religious path, with perfected omniscient liberated beings in Jainism and conditioned arising with liberation in Buddhism.

The objection. CAUTION: It may be urged that without a creator the world's very existence remains unexplained, so ultimacy is incomplete. ANALYSIS: The reply is that each system relocates the explanatory terminus - to eternal scripture and ritual order, to the duality of principles, or to the beginningless causal series - and that relocation is a philosophical position rather than an omission. The residual cost is that the resulting ultimate may not be worship-worthy in the theist's sense.

Contrast that sharpens the answer. FACT: Nyāya shows the alternative inside India: an omniscient, incorporeal, efficient cause and karmic governor, with eternal atoms still supplying the material cause - so even Indian theism does not make God the material source.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Ultimacy is achievable without creation, but not without cost: what is preserved is explanatory terminus, moral order and liberation, while personal address and providence are surrendered or relocated.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** functional thesis -> the three tasks of ultimacy -> four profiles -> objection and reply -> theistic contrast -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** eternal Veda and unseen potency; the duality of principles; the special self; non-creator paths.
- **Evidence:** the Nyāya efficient-cause profile used as a controlled contrast rather than as a proof.
- **Qualification:** the verdict states exactly which religious functions are surrendered, which prevents an over-claimed conclusion.

High-score answer protocol

1. Define before evaluating

Open with a **philosophically discriminating definition**, not a dictionary meaning.

Weak: God is supreme.

Strong: In Nyaya, Ishvara is an eternal omniscient special self functioning as the intelligent efficient cause, while atoms remain material causes.

Definitions should already separate the doctrine from its nearest rival:

Term	Definition must distinguish it from
Pantheism	Panentheism and theism
Nirguna	Nothingness and Saguna Ishvara
Aprthak-siddhi	Identity and external relation
Immanence	Physical location and pantheistic identity
Omnipotence	Contradiction-making and constant control

2. Reconstruct an argument, not merely a conclusion

Use numbered premises when the reasoning matters:

1. A substance is conceived through itself.
2. Distinct substances cannot share an attribute.
3. Absolutely infinite substance excludes every rival.
4. Therefore God/Nature is the sole substance.

Then expose the **presupposition**: does conceptual independence prove ontological independence? A Philosophy Optional answer earns marks by showing what makes the conclusion follow and where the inference can be resisted.

3. Use Sanskrit and Western terminology as precision tools

- Introduce the English meaning immediately: *aprthak-siddhi* (**inseparable existence**).
- Use the term only where it performs analytical work.
- Do not decorate generic prose with untranslated vocabulary.
- Preserve doctrinal levels: *paramarthika*, *vyavaharika*, *pratibhasika*.
- Preserve causal distinctions: *nimitta-karana* versus *upadana-karana*.
- Preserve ontological distinctions: *mithya* is neither absolutely real nor *tuccha*.

4. Compare through a constant matrix

For every cross-school answer, compare the same four variables:

NATURE -> ATTRIBUTES -> WORLD RELATION -> HUMAN RELATION

Do not write separate mini-essays that never meet. Use contrastive sentences:

"Unlike Nyaya, which separates efficient Ishvara from material atoms, Ramanuja makes Brahman both efficient and material cause through inseparable cit-acit."

5. Never conflate these four relations

IDENTITY / MODAL DEPENDENCE : Spinoza's one substance and finite modes
DEPENDENT APPEARANCE : Advaita's mithya world through vivarta
METAPHYSICAL EMBODIMENT : Ramanuja's sarira-sariri relation
EFFICIENT CAUSATION : Nyaya God ordering eternal atoms

Similarity in the word "dependence" does not erase metaphysical difference.

6. Present objection and reply dialectically

Use a three-step unit:

Example:

Objection: Evil in the world contaminates Ramanuja's embodied God.

Reply: Defect in the controlled body is not an essential predicate of its controller.

Residual pressure: Complete divine control still creates responsibility for permitted suffering.

Never present a weak objection merely to dismiss it. Steelman the rival before evaluating.

7. Make graded judgments

Avoid "completely true," "fully solved," and "both are equally valid." Prefer:

- "logically coherent but evidentially pressured,"
- "religiously adequate but metaphysically costly,"
- "preserves unity at the cost of independent plurality,"
- "valid empirically but not ultimate,"
- "answers contamination but not the entire responsibility objection."

A conclusion should name the **criterion** used: coherence, religious adequacy, explanatory economy, preservation of difference, or compatibility with moral agency.

8. Marks-wise architecture

Marks	Working time	Recommended architecture
10	7-8 min	Definition/thesis -> two doctrinal moves -> one objection/reply -> verdict
15	12-13 min	Conceptual frame -> doctrine/argument -> nearest comparison -> criticism/reply -> graded conclusion
20	17-18 min	Classification -> full reconstruction -> God-world-human implications -> two debates -> reasoned criterion-based verdict

10 marks

- About 150 words.
- One controlled comparison is enough.
- Do not spend half the answer on background.

15 marks

- About 220-250 words.
- Include at least one technical distinction and one serious criticism.
- Make every paragraph answer the directive.

20 marks

- About 320-350 words.
- Use a comparative matrix or compact diagram before prose if useful.
- Include two objections or one objection developed through reply and residual pressure.
- Rank or judge by an explicit philosophical criterion.

9. Avoid generic GS-style prose

Do not write:

"God is important for peace, harmony and moral values in society."

Write:

"A personal God can ground moral address and accountability, but the Euthyphro-type question remains whether goodness depends upon divine will or expresses an independently intelligible perfection."

Philosophy answers require doctrines, arguments, distinctions and conceptual consequences - not slogans, policy language or unanalysed moral uplift.

10. Final 20-second audit

- Did I answer the **directive**?
- Did I define the controlling term?
- Did I name the exact **relation** involved?
- Did I use God/Brahman/Ishvara carefully?
- Did I include an objection, reply and residual issue?
- Does the conclusion state **how far** the thesis succeeds?

A. Model, thinker and ultimate-reality relation

Concept/model	Thinker/school	Nature of ultimate reality	God-world / God-human relation
Classical theism	Aquinas and classical tradition	Personal, necessary, omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good	Creates and sustains distinct world; creature-creator relation
Deism	Early modern natural religion	Intelligent personal designer, non-intervening	Creates laws, then no special providence
Pantheism	Spinoza as canonical model	One infinite impersonal substance	God/Nature identity; finite beings as modes
Panentheism	Process and relational models	World-in-God, God exceeds world	Inclusion with divine excess
Substance	Spinoza	In itself and conceived through itself	Sole ontological independent reality
Attribute	Spinoza	Intellect perceives it as constituting substance's essence	Thought and Extension express one substance
Mode	Spinoza	Dependent modification	Finite mind/body exists in God, not as whole God
<i>Natura naturans</i>	Spinoza	Active self-caused nature	Infinite source considered actively
<i>Natura naturata</i>	Spinoza	Necessary order of modes	Eternal dependence, not temporal creation
Spinozistic freedom	Spinoza	Action from necessity of own nature	Human freedom grows with adequate ideas
Nirguna Brahman	Sankara/Advaita	Non-dual, non-objectifiable <i>sat-cit-ananda</i>	World dependent appearance; Atman is Brahman
Saguna Ishvara	Advaita	Brahman related to maya	Empirical creator, governor and object of worship
Maya	Advaita	Beginningless explanatory principle/power	Makes plurality appear without changing Brahman
Adhyasa	Sankara	Superimposition of self/not-self	Generates empirical jiva and bondage
Vivarta	Advaita	Apparent transformation	Brahman remains unchanged as world appears
Mithya	Advaita	Experienced, dependent, sublatable	Neither absolute reality nor sheer nothing
Three levels	Advaita	<i>Paramarthika-vyavaharika-pratibhasika</i>	Higher cognition sublates lower
Ishvara-cit-acit	Ramanuja	One personal Brahman qualified by real plurality	Organic unity of God, selves and matter

Concept/model	Thinker/school	Nature of ultimate reality	God-world / God-human relation
<i>Aprthak-siddhi</i>	Ramanuja	Inseparable existence	Jiva distinct but dependent and inseparable
<i>Sarira-sariri</i>	Ramanuja	God as indwelling Self of cosmic body	Control, support and purposive dependence
Double causation	Ramanuja	Brahman as efficient and material cause	Real cosmic manifestation through dependent acit
Bhakti and prapatti	Ramanuja	Personal God of grace	Loving contemplation and surrender; communion
Nyaya Ishvara	Nyaya-Vaisesika	Eternal omniscient special self	Orders atoms; administers karma
Nyaya causation	Nyaya	God efficient; atoms material	Intelligent arrangement without divine material transformation
<i>Karyat</i>	Udayana/Nyaya	World as effect	Effect requires intelligent maker
<i>Ayojanat</i>	Udayana/Nyaya	God as arranger	Initiates ordered atomic combination
Karma administration	Nyaya	Impartial divine governor	<i>Adrsta</i> supplies desert; God coordinates fruits
Polytheism	Hindu traditions in classificatory analysis	Several genuinely divine beings/forms	Multiple divine agencies
Henotheism	Vedic/devotional classification	Many acknowledged, one worshipped as supreme	Concentrated devotion amid plurality
Kathenotheism	Vedic classificatory model	Different gods elevated successively	Contextual supremacy
Physical manifestation	Comparative problem	Possible religious embodiment, not necessary ultimacy	Must distinguish evidence, incarnation, body and cause
Identity / appearance / embodiment / causation	Spinoza / Advaita / Ramanuja / Nyaya	Four non-equivalent models	Mode / mithya / body / atomic ordering

B. Criticism and likely UPSC demand

Concept/model	Central criticism	Likely question form
Classical theism	Evil; foreknowledge; immutable response	Are divine attributes coherent?
Deism	Religiously remote; no revelation or prayerful response	Does deism empty religion?
Pantheism	Loss of personality, providence and libertarian freedom	Is Spinoza a pantheist?
Panentheism	"In God" may remain metaphorical	Does it reconcile immanence/transcendence?
Substance	Definition-to-existence transition	Derive Spinoza's God
Attribute	Status of attributes debated	Substance-attribute relation
Mode	Derivation of finite from infinite obscure	Why is a mode not substance?
<i>Natura naturans</i>	Can "activity" fit strict necessity?	Distinguish from <i>naturata</i>
<i>Natura naturata</i>	Modal procession insufficiently transparent	Explain God-world relation
Spinozistic freedom	No alternative possibilities	Freedom or redescribed necessity?

Concept/model	Central criticism	Likely question form
Nirguna Brahman	Risk of empty abstraction	Critically examine Brahman
Saguna Ishvara	Theism remains provisional	Does Advaita leave room for theism?
Maya	Locus, concealment and <i>anirvacaniya</i> problems	Explanation or label?
Adhyasa	How can error begin in non-duality?	Explain bondage
Vivarta	May weaken world realism	Compare with parinama
Mithya	Ethical seriousness of suffering	Is world unreal?
Three levels	Risk of insulating doctrine from criticism	Explain empirical theism
Ishvara-cit-acit	Internal plurality and divine simplicity	Nature of God in Visishtadvaita
<i>Aprthak-siddhi</i>	Relation may be difficult to define without identity	God-self relation
<i>Sarira-sariri</i>	Evil in God's body	Does embodiment compromise perfection?
Double causation	Change and perfection	Compare Nyaya and Vedanta
Bhakti and prapatti	Grace-agency balance	Relation of God and man
Nyaya Ishvara	Atoms/karma may make God redundant	Nature of Nyaya God
Nyaya causation	Inference from artifacts to world-maker	Is God necessary?
<i>Karyat</i>	World may not resemble an artifact	Explain proof from effect
<i>Ayojanat</i>	Order may emerge without intention	Proof from arrangement
Karma administration	Impersonal law may suffice	Does karma render God redundant?
Polytheism	Category may oversimplify Hindu systems	Is Hinduism polytheistic?
Henotheism	May shade into monotheistic ordering	Distinguish classifications
Kathenotheism	Descriptive label, not full metaphysics	Explain Vedic plurality
Physical manifestation	Unmanifest cause may seem unverifiable	Must ultimate cause be physical?
Identity / appearance / embodiment / causation	False equivalence	Comparative 20-marker

Last-minute memory spine

PERSONALITY : personal <-> impersonal
 POSITION : transcendent <-> immanent
 POWER : omnipotence <-> logic/freedom/evil
 WORLD : identity <-> appearance <-> embodiment <-> efficient causation
 SELF : creature <-> mode <-> identity <-> inseparable jiva
 VERDICT : define -> reconstruct -> compare -> object -> reply -> grade

Before submission, add one named thinker or school to every major claim, state one residual qualification after the strongest reply, and make the last sentence answer the directive. A high-scoring script does not merely conclude that all notions are complementary; it identifies which model best satisfies the criterion chosen and what philosophical cost remains.

Answer-specific execution and compression upgrades

Use these after the detailed models; they do not replace the models.

All 13 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **All 13 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(e), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(e), 10 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q8(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 2 - 2019, Q8(b), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 3 - 2019, Q8(c), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 3 - 2019, Q8(c), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 4 - 2020, Q5(d), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 4 - 2020, Q5(d), 10 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 5 - 2020, Q7(a), 20 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 5 - 2020, Q7(a), 20 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 6 - 2021, Q5(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 6 - 2021, Q5(a), 10 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 7 - 2022, Q5(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 7 - 2022, Q5(a), 10 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 8 - 2022, Q6(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 8 - 2022, Q6(b), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 9 - 2022, Q8(c), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 9 - 2022, Q8(c), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 10 - 2023, Q5(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 10 - 2023, Q5(a), 10 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 11 - 2023, Q6(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 11 - 2023, Q6(b), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 12 - 2024, Q6(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 12 - 2024, Q6(b), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

PYQ 13 - 2024, Q8(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **PYQ 13 - 2024, Q8(b), 15 marks**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original Mains practice - full 10 / 15 / 20-mark model answers - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original Mains practice - full 10 / 15 / 20-mark model answers**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 10-marker 1 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 10-marker 1**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 10-marker 2 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 10-marker 2**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined

comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 10-marker 3 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 10-marker 3**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 15-marker 1 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 15-marker 1**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 15-marker 2 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 15-marker 2**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 15-marker 3 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 15-marker 3**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 15-marker 4 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 15-marker 4**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 20-marker 1 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 20-marker 1**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined

comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 20-marker 2 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 20-marker 2**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Original 20-marker 3 - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Original 20-marker 3**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

High-score answer protocol - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **High-score answer protocol**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.